

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

150 PSALMS

The Psalm Compass

Find the psalm for what is pressing on you today.

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

HOW TO USE IT

THREE STEPS

1. Ask yourself: *what is pressing on me today?*

2. Open the next page, find your knot, and touch the psalm.

3. Read the short page, say the prayer out loud, and close the book. That is all.

A ☾ moon marks the psalms for the night.

THE KNOT OF WORK

1 Roots by the water

15 Who may stand before God

20 For the day of the exam, the meeting, the...

26 Examine me

52 The liar will fall; I am like a green...

58 There is a God who judges the earth.

75 It is God who lifts up and who brings...

82 Defend the weak and the fatherless

108 With God we will do valiantly

119 Your word is a lamp to my feet and...

129 They have afflicted me from my youth, yet they...

THE KNOT OF SURRENDER

2 When the world rages, God still sits on his...

8 You are small, and you are loved

9 Thank him out loud for what he has already...

14 A prayer when it looks as if nobody believes...

16 ☾ You are my portion; the path of life is...

18 He brought me out into a broad place, because...

19 The heavens tell his glory; then ask to be...

21 Thanks for the prayer he already granted.

24 Lift up the gates of your heart so the...

31 My times are in your hand," the prayer for...

33 Sing a new song

36 His love is higher than the mountains

THE KNOT OF SURRENDER

47 Clap your hands

48 Walk around his city in your mind and count...

50 Offer thanks as your sacrifice and keep your vows.

66 Come and hear what he has done for my...

76 Even human anger ends up praising him

87 This one was born there

92 Still bearing fruit in old age, fresh and green.

93 The floods lift up their voice, but he is...

95 Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden...

96 Sing to the Lord a new song; declare his...

97 Light is sown for the righteous, and gladness for...

98 Sing to the Lord a new song; he has...

THE KNOT OF SURRENDER

99 The Lord is holy

100 Enter his gates with thanksgiving

104 Everything on earth depends on his open hand.

105 Remember the wonders he has done in your own...

110 A psalm of promise

111 His works are great

114 Tremble, earth, at the presence of the Lord.

115 Not to us, O Lord, but to your name...

117 The shortest psalm

118 His mercy endures forever

124 If the Lord hadn't been on our side, the...

132 A prayer to make a dwelling for him in...

THE KNOT OF SURRENDER

135 Praise his name

136 His mercy endures forever

138 You answered me on the day I called.

145 Every day I will bless you

148 Let everything praise him, from the sun to the...

149 Let his people rejoice, even on their beds.

150 The last word is praise

THE KNOT OF PEACE

3 ☾ I lay down and slept"

4 ☾ Peace to lie down and sleep

5 A morning prayer when someone is speaking against you.

10 When God seems to hide in your hour of...

11 When the foundations shake, he is still in his...

12 When no one seems honest, his words are pure...

13 ☾ How long?" The prayer for a worn-out heart that...

22 ☾ My God, why?" The prayer of the darkest hour,...

23 ☾ The Lord is my shepherd

27 ☾ Whom shall I fear? One thing I ask

28 When the silence is so loud you fear he...

29 His voice is over the storm, and he blesses...

THE KNOT OF PEACE

34 Taste and see

42 ☾ As the deer pants for water

43 Send out your light and your truth to lead...

44 Rouse yourself, Lord

46 ☾ Be still, and know that I am God.

53 A prayer when it looks as if God has...

54 God is my helper

56 ☾ You keep my tears in your bottle

57 ☾ In the shadow of your wings I take refuge.

59 ☾ Guard me through the night; I will sing of...

62 ☾ For God alone my soul waits in silence.

63 ☾ On my bed I remember you in the watches...

THE KNOT OF PEACE

64 ☾ Hide me from the whisperers

68 A father to the fatherless, a defender of widows.

74 Remember your people

77 ☾ I cry aloud to God"

83 God, do not keep silent

88 ☾ The one psalm with no light at the end

91 ☾ Under his wings you will not fear the terror...

102 ☾ Like a lonely bird on the housetop

120 In my distress I cried to the Lord, and...

121 ☾ He who keeps you will not slumber"

125 Those who trust in the Lord are like Mount...

131 ☾ A quieted soul, like a weaned child with its...

THE KNOT OF PEACE

134 ☾ Lift up your hands in the sanctuary at night…

137 By the rivers of Babylon we sat and wept

139 ☾ You know me when I sit and when I…

140 Rescue me from cruel tongues, and keep my steps…

141 ☾ Let my prayer rise like incense; let my hands…

142 ☾ No one cares for my soul

THE KNOT OF HEALTH

6 ☾ Faint and worn out? Ask for mercy, plainly, tonight.

30 ☾ You turned my mourning into dancing

38 Heavy with pain and regret at once

39 My days are a handbreadth

41 He sustains the one who is sick

71 Do not cast me away in my old age.

90 Teach us to count our days so that we...

116 I was brought low and he saved me

147 He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.

THE KNOT OF FORGIVENESS

7 Falsely accused

25 Do not remember the sins of my youth

32 Blessed is the one whose sin is forgiven

35 Plead my cause when people repay good with harm.

51 Create in me a clean heart

73 Why do the wicked prosper? Then you enter his...

79 Help us, God of our salvation, and forgive our...

94 When injustice stings, the Lord does not forsake his...

103 He forgives all your sins and crowns you with...

109 When the whole town speaks against you, give yourself...

130 ☾ Out of the depths I cry to you

143 ☾ Do not enter into judgment with your servant.

THE KNOT OF CHILDREN

17 ☾ Keep us as the apple of your eye, hidden…

67 May God be gracious to us and bless us

78 Tell your children what God has done

89 I will sing of his love forever

113 He lifts the poor from the dust and makes…

144 May our sons be like plants and our daughters…

THE KNOT OF MONEY

37 Do not fret about others

49 Money cannot redeem a life

65 You crown the year with your bounty

69 The waters have come up to my neck

70 Hurry, Lord, to help me

72 A king who defends the needy

86 Bow down your ear, Lord, for I am poor...

112 The upright are blessed

123 Have mercy on us; we have had more than...

146 He upholds the widow and the fatherless

THE KNOT OF RETURN

40 I waited patiently, and he lifted me out of...

60 You have rejected us

61 From the end of the earth I call

80 Turn us again, God

81 Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it.

84 How lovely is your dwelling place

106 We have sinned like our fathers

107 Let the redeemed of the Lord say so

126 Those who sow in tears will reap with songs...

133 How good and pleasant when brothers live together in...

THE KNOT OF MARRIAGE

45 A wedding song

55 ☾ It was you, my companion"

85 Mercy and truth meet; righteousness and peace kiss.

101 I will walk with integrity within my house.

122 I was glad when they said

127 ☾ Unless the Lord builds the house

128 Your children like olive shoots around your table.



PSALM 1

Roots by the water: stay planted and you will not wither.

READ IT WHEN…

you can't tell which road to take, and every voice in the house and on the phone pulls you a different way.

WHAT IT SAYS

This psalm says there are two ways to live. One person lets every loud voice steer him. Another puts down roots in God's word, like a tree beside a stream, and bears fruit in its own season. The first is blown off like chaff; the Lord knows the other's way.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Your choices don't need a quick answer today. They need roots. Read one small line of Scripture each morning, before the phone, and let it be the stream you stand beside.

He will be like a tree planted by the streams of water, that produces its fruit in its season, whose leaf also does not wither. Whatever he does shall prosper.

PSALM 1:3 (WEB)

Lord, I'm tired of being blown about. Plant me by your water, and show me the next step, only the next one. I'll stay put until you do.



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PSALM 2

When the world rages, God still sits on his throne.

READ IT WHEN…

the news is loud, the world looks like it's coming apart, and you wonder if anyone is still in charge.

WHAT IT SAYS

The nations rage and the rulers plot against God, and he is not shaken. He sits in heaven, and he has already set his King in place. The psalm ends by pointing to the one safe place: those who take refuge in him are blessed.

FOR YOUR KNOT

The world's noise is a knot of surrender: you can't fix it, and you keep trying. Turn off the television for one hour today and sit in your chair. Tell God the headline you can't carry. The throne is not empty.

Yet I have set my King on my holy hill of Zion.

PSALM 2:6 (WEB)

Lord, the world is loud and I am small. I give you the headlines, the rulers and the fear. You are still on the throne; I'm taking refuge in you.



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PSALM 3

☾ For the night

"I lay down and slept": for the nights when the people who turned on you keep you awake.

READ IT WHEN…

worry about people who turned against you keeps you staring at the ceiling, and the night feels full of voices.

PSALM 3

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer is surrounded by people saying God won't help him. Even so, he calls out, and God answers. Then comes the line: he lay down, slept, and woke again, because the Lord sustained him. He won't be afraid, even of crowds against him.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Your knot of peace may be one person who spoke against you. Tonight, say that name once to God, then put the phone face down. Sleep is something he sustains; you don't have to earn it.

I laid myself down and slept. I awakened, for the LORD sustains me.

PSALM 3:5 (WEB)

Lord, you are the shield around me tonight. I give you the names that keep me awake. Let me lie down and sleep, and wake up because you sustained me.



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✦ PSALM 4 ✦

☾ For the night

Peace to lie down and sleep: the best psalm for a restless bed.

READ IT WHEN…

you're in bed, the day's troubles are still talking, and you want one quiet sentence to carry you to morning.

PSALM 4

WHAT IT SAYS

A person in distress asks God to answer, and reminds himself that God hears when he calls. He is told to search his heart on his bed and be still. He ends by saying God has given him more gladness than a full harvest, and he can sleep safely.

FOR YOUR KNOT

"Be still on your bed" is the instruction. Say one worry aloud, then answer it with this verse. Peace here isn't the end of problems; it's a safe place to lie down while they wait for morning.

In peace I will both lay myself down and sleep, for you alone, LORD, make me live in safety.

PSALM 4:8 (WEB)

Lord, hear me when I call. I put the day down at the foot of this bed. Make me lie down in peace and sleep, because you alone keep me safe.



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PSALM 5

A morning prayer when someone is speaking against you.

READ IT WHEN…

you wake up knowing someone is speaking against you, and you can already feel the phone call you would like to make.

PSALM 5

WHAT IT SAYS

This is a morning prayer. The writer lays his requests before God at daybreak and waits to see what comes. He knows liars and flatterers are around him, and he asks God to lead him straight. He finishes with joy for those who take refuge in God, who shields them.

FOR YOUR KNOT

When someone's tongue is cutting you, the first move is not a reply. Pray before the first cup of coffee, set your request down, and watch for how God answers today. Answer them later, if at all.

the LORD, in the morning you will hear my voice. In the morning I will lay my requests before you, and will watch expectantly.

PSALM 5:3 (WEB)

Good morning, Lord. Here is what's being said about me. I won't answer it before I've answered to you. Lead me straight today, and be my shield.



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PSALM 6

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

Faint and worn out? Ask for mercy, plainly, tonight.

READ IT WHEN…

you're worn thin by pain or by a long illness, and you've been crying into the pillow where no one can hear.

PSALM 6

WHAT IT SAYS

A worn-out person asks God for mercy: he is faint, his bones ache and his soul is troubled. He cries every night until the bed is wet. He asks, "How long?" Then the psalm turns and he says God has heard his weeping and accepts his prayer.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Health is the knot here, and the psalm doesn't pretend. It gives you words for the weariness. Ask for mercy plainly, then ask the doctor your questions tomorrow. Being tired is not a failure of faith.

Have mercy on me, LORD, for I am faint. LORD, heal me, for my bones are troubled.

PSALM 6:2 (WEB)

Lord, I'm worn out and I'm not going to pretend otherwise. Have mercy on me tonight. Hear my weeping, and give my body and my heart some rest.



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PSALM 7

Falsely accused: hand the case to the true Judge.

READ IT WHEN…

someone has blamed you for something you didn't do, and you keep rehearsing your defense in the shower and in the car.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer says he has done nothing wrong and asks God to judge him honestly. He trusts God as a righteous judge who sees hearts. He also notes that those who dig a pit for others tend to fall into it themselves. He ends by thanking God.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Forgiveness starts with putting down the case. Write your side once on paper, hand it to God as to the true Judge, and fold it away. You don't have to win this one alone.

My shield is with God, who saves the upright in heart.

PSALM 7:10 (WEB)

Lord, you know what's in my hands and in my heart. I'm tired of defending myself. I leave the case with you, the one Judge who sees everything.



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PSALM 8

You are small, and you are loved: look at the night sky.

READ IT WHEN…

you feel small and forgotten, nobody has called in days, and the night sky out the window is the only company.

PSALM 8

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer looks up at the moon and stars and wonders why God would notice a human being at all. Yet God does think of us, has made us only a little lower than the angels, and has given us work to do. The psalm begins and ends with praise.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Being small is not the same as being unimportant. Step onto the porch or to a window tonight and look up for one minute. Say it quietly: he thinks of me.

When I consider your heavens, the work of your fingers, the moon and the stars, which you have ordained, what is man, that you think of him? What is the son of man, that you care for him?

PSALM 8:3-4 (WEB)

Lord, the sky is huge and I'm small. Thank you for thinking of me anyway. Help me believe it when no one else calls tonight.



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PSALM 9

Thank him out loud for what he has already done.

READ IT WHEN…

things turned out better than you feared, and you haven't yet said thank you out loud to anyone, least of all to God.

PSALM 9

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer gives thanks with his whole heart and promises to tell of God's marvelous works. He remembers that God sat on his throne and defended his cause. God is a high tower for the oppressed and never forgets the cry of the afflicted or the hope of the poor.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Gratitude shows you what has already come undone. Name three things from the last year that worked out, and say a thank-you for each one out loud, standing in your own kitchen.

I will give thanks to the LORD with my whole heart. I will tell of all your marvelous works.

PSALM 9:1 (WEB)

Lord, I thank you with my whole heart. Let me say it out loud: you have been faithful. Remind me of what you've done when I forget.



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PSALM 10

When God seems to hide in your hour of need.

READ IT WHEN…

you've prayed and prayed and it feels like God has stepped out of the room, just when you needed him most.

PSALM 10

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks, "Why do you stand far off?" He describes people who prosper by pushing the weak aside and say God has forgotten. Then he says the opposite: God does see trouble and grief, helps the victim, and hears the desire of the humble.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Feeling that God is far away is a real knot, and this psalm is allowed to say so. Ask the question aloud: "Where are you?" Then stay in the chair five more minutes and let the question be your prayer.

But you do see trouble and grief. You consider it to take it into your hand. You help the victim and the fatherless.

PSALM 10:14 (WEB)

Lord, why do you seem so far away? I'm asking it honestly. Come near anyway, and let me know you see my trouble even when I can't feel you.



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PSALM 11

When the foundations shake, he is still in his holy place.

READ IT WHEN…

your whole footing seems to be going, the job, the savings, the health, the family, and someone says, "Just run away."

PSALM 11

WHAT IT SAYS

Friends tell the writer to flee like a bird to the mountains because the foundations are being destroyed. He answers that he takes refuge in the Lord, who is on his throne and sees everyone. The psalm ends with a promise: the upright shall see God's face.

FOR YOUR KNOT

When the ground shakes, don't run in circles. Make a short list of what is actually collapsing and what is still standing. Then sit and tell God the list. He is still where he was.

The LORD is in his holy temple. The LORD is on his throne in heaven. His eyes observe. His eyes examine the children of men.

PSALM 11:4 (WEB)

Lord, the ground feels like it's moving under me. I'm not running. I take refuge in you, because you are still on your throne and you see me.



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PSALM 12

When no one seems honest, his words are pure silver.

READ IT WHEN…

it seems nobody tells the truth anymore: not the salesman, not the news, not the people who should know better.

PSALM 12

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer says help is needed because honest people are hard to find and everyone lies to neighbors with flattering lips. God answers that he will rise to protect the poor and the groaning. His words, unlike human words, are flawless, like silver refined seven times.

FOR YOUR KNOT

When everybody is selling something, one steady voice matters. Read a single line of Scripture slowly, twice, as if it were the only honest word you'd hear all day. Keep it in your pocket like a silver coin.

> *The LORD's words are flawless words, as silver refined in a clay furnace, purified seven times.*
>
> PSALM 12:6 (WEB)

Lord, so many words today, and so few true ones. Let your word be the one I trust. Keep me honest, and keep me safe from the lies around me.



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PSALM 13

FOR THE NIGHT

"How long?" The prayer for a worn-out heart that still trusts.

READ IT WHEN…

you've waited so long for an answer that you've started to wonder whether anyone is listening, and it is late.

PSALM 13

WHAT IT SAYS

Four times in two verses the writer says "How long?" He feels forgotten and worn out with sorrow, and asks God to give light to his eyes. In the last verses, with nothing yet changed, he decides to trust and sings that God has been good to him.

FOR YOUR KNOT

This is the prayer for a heart that is tired but still trusting. Say "How long?" out loud once, with no apology. Then say one sentence you know is true about God's goodness, even if you don't feel it.

> *But I trust in your loving kindness. My heart rejoices in your salvation.*
>
> PSALM 13:5 (WEB)

How long, Lord? I'm asking plainly. Give light to my eyes tonight, and let me trust you even while I wait. You have been good to me before.



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PSALM 14

A prayer when it looks as if nobody believes anymore.

READ IT WHEN…

it looks as if hardly anyone believes anymore, when church pews are emptier and your own children don't pray.

PSALM 14

WHAT IT SAYS

The psalm opens with a hard picture: people who say in their hearts that there is no God, and everyone going the wrong way. But the Lord looks down from heaven to see who seeks him. He is the refuge of the poor, and the psalm ends with hope that he will restore his people.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Don't carry the whole world's belief on your shoulders. Your part is small and real: seek God today, in your own chair, and trust that he is already looking for those who do.

The LORD looked down from heaven on the children of men, to see if there were any who understood, who sought after God.

PSALM 14:2 (WEB)

Lord, you look down and see who is seeking you. Here I am. Be the refuge of everyone I love who has stopped praying, and restore what has been lost.



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PSALM 15

Who may stand before God: the one with honest hands.

READ IT WHEN…

a coworker has offered you a shortcut, or a favor that bends the truth a little, and you want to go home with clean hands.

PSALM 15

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks who may live in God's presence. The answer is the person who walks honestly, speaks truth in his heart, doesn't slander or harm a friend, keeps a promise even when it costs, and takes no bribe. The one who lives like this will never be shaken.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Work is the knot. Choose one small place today where the honest thing costs you something, such as a rounded number or a promise to a customer, and do it. Integrity gets built in ordinary hours, not grand ones.

He who walks blamelessly and does what is right, and speaks truth in his heart;

PSALM 15:2 (WEB)

Lord, make my hands honest today. Keep my word true when it costs me, and keep my tongue from cruel talk. Let me stand steady at my work.



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16

PSALM 16

FOR THE NIGHT

You are my portion; the path of life is in your hand.

READ IT WHEN…

you're lying awake sorting what you have from what you've lost, and you need to remember that you are held.

PSALM 16

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer says, "Keep me safe, God, for I take refuge in you. Apart from you I have no good thing." He sees his life as a plot of land God measured out for him, and calls it good. Even at night his heart teaches him, and he ends with the path of life.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Trust is counting what you were given instead of what is missing. Tonight, list three things that are still yours: a person, a place, a morning. Then read the verse once more and let it settle.

I have set the LORD always before me. Because he is at my right hand, I shall not be moved.

PSALM 16:8 (WEB)

Lord, you are my portion and my cup. Tonight I count what I still have, not what I've lost. I set you before me, and I will not be moved.



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PSALM 17

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

Keep us as the apple of your eye, hidden in your wings.

READ IT WHEN…

you're afraid for the people you love, a child out late, a grandchild far away, and you can't protect them from here.

PSALM 17

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks God to hear a plea made with honest lips. He says God has searched his heart at night and found nothing false. Then he asks to be kept like the apple of God's eye and hidden under his wings, and he ends expecting to see God's face when he wakes.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You can't stand guard over everyone tonight, but you can hand them over by name. Say each name aloud, once, and add, "Keep them as the apple of your eye." Then rest; you've done your part.

> *Keep me as the apple of your eye. Hide me under the shadow of your wings,*
>
> PSALM 17:8 (WEB)

Lord, I can't watch over them, but you can. Keep the people I love as the apple of your eye, hidden under your wings tonight, and let me sleep.



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PSALM 18

He brought me out into a broad place, because he delighted in me.

READ IT WHEN…

a hard season is finally behind you, and you want to say out loud what it felt like to be pulled from deep water.

PSALM 18

WHAT IT SAYS

This is a long song of thanks. The writer was wrapped in the cords of death and cried out in his distress. God heard him, reached down from on high, and drew him out of many waters into a wide, open place, because he delighted in him.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Think of one season you didn't think you'd get through. Write one line telling how it ended. Rescue stories are worth saying aloud, because you'll lean on them the next time the water rises.

> *He brought me out also into a large place. He delivered me, because he delighted in me.*
>
> PSALM 18:19 (WEB)

Lord, you are my rock and my fortress. Thank you for drawing me out of deep water and into a wide place. Help me remember it the next time I'm afraid.



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PSALM 19

The heavens tell his glory; then ask to be made clean.

READ IT WHEN…

you've been looking out at the morning and the world feels bigger than your troubles, and you want your words to be clean.

PSALM 19

WHAT IT SAYS

The first half says the sky speaks without words, day after day, and the sun runs its course like a strong man. The second half turns to God's law, which restores the soul and is sweeter than honey. It ends with a prayer to be forgiven hidden faults and to speak and think rightly.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Start the day under the open sky, even from the doorstep, and say this prayer before you speak to anyone. Ask to be made clean from the faults you can't see for yourself.

> *Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, LORD, my rock, and my redeemer.*
>
> PSALM 19:14 (WEB)

Lord, the sky tells of your glory every day. Forgive the faults I can't see, and let the words of my mouth and the thoughts of my heart please you.



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PSALM 20

For the day of the exam, the meeting, the decision.

READ IT WHEN…

there's an exam, an interview, a hearing or an important meeting tomorrow, and you can't stop running through it in your head.

PSALM 20

WHAT IT SAYS

This is a blessing said over someone about to face a big day. It asks that God answer in the day of trouble, send help, and grant the desires of the heart. It ends with a quiet confidence: some trust in chariots and horses, but we trust the name of the Lord.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Do your preparing, then stop. Set out the papers, the clothes, the keys, and say this blessing over them. The rest of the night is not for rehearsing. Whatever the day brings, you won't walk into it alone.

Some trust in chariots, and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.

PSALM 20:7 (WEB)

Lord, I've done what I can. Answer me on the day of trouble, send me help, and let me trust you more than my own preparing.



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PSALM 21

Thanks for the prayer he already granted.

READ IT WHEN…

a prayer you had almost stopped praying has been answered, and you want to say so before the feeling fades.

PSALM 21

WHAT IT SAYS

A king rejoices because God has given him what he asked and has not held back the request of his lips. God met him with blessings, gave him life and put gladness in his heart. The king trusts the Lord, and so he will not be shaken.

FOR YOUR KNOT

A granted prayer deserves a thank-you as sincere as the asking. Write down what you asked and what happened, then say thank you slowly. Keep the paper to read on the days you doubt.

> *You have given him his heart's desire, and have not withheld the request of his lips. Selah.*
>
> PSALM 21:2 (WEB)

Lord, you gave me what I asked, and I almost didn't notice. Thank you. Let my gladness be as honest as my asking was.



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PSALM 22

☾ For the night

"My God, why?" The prayer of the darkest hour, and where it ends.

READ IT WHEN…

you feel completely forsaken, in the darkest hour, and you've run out of polite words to say to God.

WHAT IT SAYS

It begins with the cry Jesus later prayed, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" The writer describes being mocked, drained and alone. Yet he remembers how God helped before, and at the turn he says God did not hide his face but heard him. It ends in praise for the next generation.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You may say the first line exactly as it stands. Honest sorrow is allowed here. Say it, then stay in the quiet and listen. The psalm doesn't end where it started, and neither do you.

For he has not despised nor abhorred the affliction of the afflicted, neither has he hidden his face from him; but when he cried to him, he heard.

PSALM 22:24 (WEB)

My God, my God, why? I'm too tired for pretty words. Stay with me in this dark, and hear me as you have heard every cry before mine.



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✦ PSALM 23 ✦

☾ For the night

The Lord is my shepherd: the walk through the dark valley.

READ IT WHEN…

you must walk alone through something dark, a hospital hallway, an empty house at night, a graveside, and you need company.

WHAT IT SAYS

The Lord is a shepherd who gives the writer all he needs. He leads him to quiet water and restores his soul. When the path runs through the darkest valley, the writer will fear no evil, because God is with him, with rod and staff. He ends with goodness following him all his days.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Notice the word "through." The valley is not where you live; it's a place you pass through, and you aren't passing alone. Say "you are with me" slowly, once for every step down the hall.

> *Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me. Your rod and your staff, they comfort me.*
>
> PSALM 23:4 (WEB)

Lord, you are my shepherd. I'm walking through a dark place tonight, and I'm not afraid, because you are with me. Stay close, and comfort me.



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PSALM 24

Lift up the gates of your heart so the King may come in.

READ IT WHEN…

you want to make room for God in a heart that has felt shut up, and you don't know how to begin.

PSALM 24

WHAT IT SAYS

The earth and everything in it belong to the Lord. The psalm asks who may come to his holy place, and answers: one with clean hands and a pure heart. Then it turns into a welcome: lift up your heads, you gates, so the King of glory may come in.

FOR YOUR KNOT

A heart can be like a door that's been closed a long time. Tonight, open one thing in your home, a window or a door, and say quietly: come in. Let that be your welcome.

Lift up your heads, you gates! Be lifted up, you everlasting doors, and the King of glory will come in.

PSALM 24:7 (WEB)

Lord, the door has been shut a long time. Come in. Clean the rooms I've closed, and stay as long as you like. This house is yours.



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PSALM 25

Do not remember the sins of my youth: a prayer for old regrets.

READ IT WHEN…

an old mistake from years ago still wakes you at night, and you wish someone could tell you that it's over.

PSALM 25

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer lifts his soul to God and asks to be taught his ways. He asks God not to remember the sins of his youth, but to remember him by his kindness. He admits his guilt is great and still asks for pardon. He also says God guides the humble.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Tell God the old thing plainly, once, using its right name. Then ask him to remember you by his kindness and not by your record. What he forgives, you may stop punishing yourself for.

Don't remember the sins of my youth, nor my transgressions. Remember me according to your loving kindness, for your goodness' sake, the LORD.

PSALM 25:7 (WEB)

Lord, you know what I did long ago. I'm asking you not to remember it, and to remember me by your kindness instead. Teach me your way again.



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PSALM 26

Examine me: I have walked honestly in my work and home.

READ IT WHEN…

you want to look honestly at your work and your home, and ask whether you've been fair to the people around you.

PSALM 26

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks God to test his heart and mind, because he has tried to walk honestly and to trust without wavering. He has kept away from deceit and from people who take bribes. He loves God's house, promises to give thanks, and says his foot stands on level ground.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Use this psalm like an evening look at the ledger. Ask: where was I straight today, and where was I crooked? Don't make a long list. Name one of each, and give both to God.

> *Examine me, LORD, and prove me. Try my heart and my mind.*
>
> PSALM 26:2 (WEB)

Lord, examine my heart tonight. Show me where I was fair and where I wasn't. Forgive what I did wrong, and keep my feet on level ground.



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27

PSALM 27

FOR THE NIGHT

Whom shall I fear? One thing I ask: to dwell with him.

READ IT WHEN…

fear has settled in your chest, about money, a test result, a quiet house, and you need one sentence to hold onto.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks, "Whom shall I fear?" because the Lord is his light and the strength of his life. Even if an army camps against him, his heart won't be afraid. He asks for one thing, to live close to God. It closes with advice to himself: wait for the Lord, be strong, take courage.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say verse one aloud, slowly, with your hand over your heart. Then make "one thing" your plan for today: to stay near him. Fear loosens a little when your whole heart is asking for just one thing.

> *The LORD is my light and my salvation. Whom shall I fear? The LORD is the strength of my life. Of whom shall I be afraid?*
>
> PSALM 27:1 (WEB)

Lord, you are my light and my strength. I won't let fear sit at the head of my table tonight. Teach me to wait, and make my heart brave.



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28

PSALM 28

When the silence is so loud you fear he has gone deaf.

READ IT WHEN…

you've been praying into a silence so heavy that you're afraid God has gone deaf, and the phone doesn't ring either.

PSALM 28

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer cries out to the Lord, his rock, and begs him not to be silent. He lifts his hands and asks to be kept apart from people who speak peace and plan harm. Then the mood changes: he blesses God because he has heard, and says the Lord is his strength and shield.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Lift your hands, as the psalm does, even if only to your shoulders. Say your petition once, then stay quiet for a full minute. Silence is not always a no. Sometimes it is only God listening closely.

> *Blessed be the LORD, because he has heard the voice of my petitions.*
>
> PSALM 28:6 (WEB)

Lord, don't be silent with me. I lift my hands and my voice. Hear my petition, and be my strength and my shield even while I wait.



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PSALM 29

His voice is over the storm, and he blesses his people with peace.

READ IT WHEN…

a storm is going over your house, real weather or something harder, and you want to hear a voice stronger than the wind.

WHAT IT SAYS

The psalm describes the voice of the Lord moving over the water, breaking cedars, shaking the wilderness and flashing like lightning. In his temple, everything says, "Glory!" Then it closes quietly: the Lord, enthroned over the flood, gives strength to his people and blesses them with peace.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Next time the wind rises, or the bad news does, listen for how this psalm ends, not how it begins. Say it twice: the Lord will bless his people with peace. The storm is loud, but it isn't in charge.

The LORD will give strength to his people. The LORD will bless his people with peace.

PSALM 29:11 (WEB)

Lord, your voice is louder than any storm. Give me your strength today, and bless me and my family with your peace while the wind is still blowing.



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30

PSALM 30

FOR THE NIGHT

You turned my mourning into dancing: a thanks after illness or loss.

READ IT WHEN…

the worst of an illness or a loss has passed, and you're tired but carefully glad, and want to thank God for it.

PSALM 30

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer thanks God for lifting him up, healing him and keeping him alive. He admits he once thought he would never be shaken, and then trouble came. He cried for mercy, and God turned his mourning into dancing. He promises to give thanks forever.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Weeping may stay the night, and joy comes in the morning; both lines are true. Mark the end of the hard season with something small today: light a candle, call a friend, say thank you out loud.

For his anger is but for a moment. His favor is for a lifetime. Weeping may stay for the night, but joy comes in the morning.

PSALM 30:5 (WEB)

Lord, you lifted me when I couldn't stand. Thank you for turning my mourning into something close to dancing. Keep my heart giving thanks.



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PSALM 31

"My times are in your hand," the prayer for every tomorrow.

READ IT WHEN…

the future looks like a closed door, a hearing, a bill, a visit you dread, and you need to hand it over.

PSALM 31

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer takes refuge in God and places his spirit in God's hands. He is in distress, worn out with grief, avoided by neighbors and forgotten like broken pottery. Even so he says, "You are my God," and declares that his times are in God's hand.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Pick the one tomorrow that frightens you most. Say its name aloud, then say, "My times are in your hand." Say it again at noon. You aren't handing over your effort, only the weight.

My times are in your hand. Deliver me from the hand of my enemies, and from those who persecute me.

PSALM 31:15 (WEB)

Lord, you hold my tomorrows better than I do. Into your hand I put this week, this worry and this body. I'll do my part; you carry the rest.



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PSALM 32

Blessed is the one whose sin is forgiven: the lightness after confession.

READ IT WHEN…

you have finally told the truth about something you did, and what you feel is not shame but a strange, light quiet.

PSALM 32

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer describes how heavy his silence was: his bones wasted, and God's hand pressed on him day and night. Then he confessed, hiding nothing, and God forgave. Now he calls the forgiven person blessed, says God is his hiding place, and promises to guide him.

FOR YOUR KNOT

If something still lies unconfessed, this is the psalm for naming it. If you've already confessed, sit with the lightness. Don't pick the burden back up. Forgiven means finished.

Blessed is he whose disobedience is forgiven, whose sin is covered.

PSALM 32:1 (WEB)

Lord, thank you for taking this weight from me. I told you the truth and you forgave. Be my hiding place, and keep me from picking it up again.



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33

PSALM 33

Sing a new song: a morning to simply praise.

READ IT WHEN…

you wake up and nothing is wrong, just a plain morning, and you want to give God a few minutes of thanks.

PSALM 33

WHAT IT SAYS

Come with a new song, says the psalm. God's word is right and the earth is full of his kindness; by his word the heavens were made. No army or horse can save a king. God's eye is on those who hope in him, and our heart waits for him as our help and shield.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Put on a song you love, or hum one while you make the coffee. Praise doesn't need a big reason today. Let it be small, sung once, for a God who made the morning.

> *Sing to him a new song. Play skillfully with a shout of joy!*
>
> PSALM 33:3 (WEB)

Lord, I have nothing to ask this morning. I just want to sing. Thank you for the light, the kitchen, and the day you made.



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PSALM 34

Taste and see: he is near the brokenhearted.

READ IT WHEN…

your heart is broken, a death, a betrayal, a child who stopped calling, and you can't find words big enough.

PSALM 34

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer says he sought the Lord, and the Lord heard him and saved him from all his fears. He invites us to taste and see that the Lord is good. The Lord's ears hear the cry of the righteous, and he is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Taste is something you do, not think. Do one small good thing slowly today, a warm drink or a short walk, and say, "Lord, I'm tasting this." He is near you now, with your heart just as it is.

The LORD is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit.

PSALM 34:18 (WEB)

Lord, my heart is broken and I have no good words. You promised to be near. Stay close, and save what is crushed in me.



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PSALM 35

Plead my cause when people repay good with harm.

READ IT WHEN…

people you helped have repaid kindness with harm, and the sting of it is worse than any loss.

PSALM 35

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks God to take his side against people who attack him without cause. They hid a net for him for no reason. He had mourned and prayed for them when they were sick, and now they gloat when he stumbles. He asks God to see it and not be far.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Write the name of the one who hurt you, and beside it what you did for them. Hand the page to God and say: you saw it. Forgiving may come later; today you only put the case down.

> *You have seen it, the LORD. Don’t keep silent. Lord, don’t be far from me.*
>
> PSALM 35:22 (WEB)

Lord, you saw it, all of it. Don't be far from me. Be fair where I can't be, and keep bitterness from taking over my heart.



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PSALM 36

His love is higher than the mountains: read it on a small day.

READ IT WHEN…

it's a small day, nothing dramatic, just ordinary worries, and you need to remember how big his love is.

PSALM 36

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer first describes someone who has no fear of God and plots wrong even on his bed. Then he lifts his eyes: God's love reaches the heavens, his faithfulness the skies, and his justice is like the mountains.People take refuge in his wings, and with him is the spring of life.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Look at the sky for a minute today, or at the nearest tree, and say, "Your love reaches higher than this." Small days are when a large love is easiest to forget, and most worth remembering.

Your loving kindness, LORD, is in the heavens. Your faithfulness reaches to the skies.

PSALM 36:5 (WEB)

Lord, your love is higher than the sky and deeper than my worry. On this small day, let me drink from your spring and take refuge under your wings.



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37

PSALM 37

Do not fret about others: a little with righteousness is enough.

READ IT WHEN…

a neighbor or relative seems to be doing better while you count coins at the end of the month, and envy is creeping in.

PSALM 37

WHAT IT SAYS

Don't fret over those who prosper by wrong, says the psalm; they fade like grass. Trust the Lord, do good, delight in him, and wait patiently. A little with righteousness is better than the abundance of many. The writer, now old, has never seen the righteous forsaken or their children begging for bread.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Envy is a money knot. Today, name one thing you have that money didn't buy. Then take one practical step on one bill. Rest in the Lord and wait patiently; envy only adds interest.

Better is a little that the righteous has, than the abundance of many wicked.

PSALM 37:16 (WEB)

Lord, I'm tired of comparing. Help me trust you and do good with what I have. Teach me that a little with you is better than a lot without.



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PSALM 38

Heavy with pain and regret at once: do not leave me, Lord.

READ IT WHEN…

your body hurts and your conscience hurts too, and you can't tell which is heavier on the pillow.

PSALM 38

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer is in pain, bowed down, and says his own mistakes are a weight too heavy for him. His strength fails, his friends keep away, and others plot against him. He stays quiet and hopes in God, confesses his wrong, and ends with a plain plea: don't forsake me, hurry to help me.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Pain and regret pile onto each other, so pull them apart. Tell God the body part first, then the regret, one sentence each. He can carry two things at once. Then ask your doctor the question you've been holding, and your priest or pastor the other one.

Don’t forsake me, the LORD.
My God, don’t be far from me.

PSALM 38:21 (WEB)

Lord, my body aches and my heart aches too. Don't leave me, and don't stay far. Hurry to help me, and forgive what I carry.



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PSALM 39

My days are a handbreadth: I wait for you.

READ IT WHEN…

a birthday, a funeral or a doctor's visit reminds you how few years are left, and you aren't sure what to do with that.

PSALM 39

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer tried to keep quiet, but his heart burned and he spoke: show me how short my days are. He says life is a handbreadth, a breath, a shadow. Then he asks what he is waiting for, and answers himself: my hope is in you. He asks God to hear his tears.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Instead of fear, let the short days make you gentle. Pick one person you've been meaning to call or forgive, and do it today. Hours count most when you spend them on someone.

> *Now, Lord, what do I wait for? My hope is in you.*
>
> PSALM 39:7 (WEB)

Lord, my days are short, so teach me to spend them well. My hope is in you. Hear my tears, and give me one good thing to do today.



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40

PSALM 40

I waited patiently, and he lifted me out of the pit.

READ IT WHEN…

you're waiting for someone to come home or a door to open, and wonder whether patience is just a polite word for giving up.

PSALM 40

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer waited patiently, and God turned to him, heard his cry, and lifted him out of a pit onto a rock, putting a new song in his mouth. Later he admits troubles pile up beyond counting and asks God to hurry. He ends calling himself poor and needy, with God as his help.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Waiting is work too. Keep one small, steady habit while you wait: set the table, leave the porch light on, say the name. Waiting in a rhythm is different from waiting in a worry.

I waited patiently for the LORD. He turned to me, and heard my cry. He brought me up also out of a horrible pit, out of the miry clay. He set my feet on a rock, and gave me a firm place to stand.

PSALM 40:1-2 (WEB)

Lord, I'm still waiting, and I'm tired. Lift me and set my feet on a rock. Don't delay, my God, and keep me faithful in the waiting.



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41

PSALM 41

He sustains the one who is sick: a prayer by the bed.

READ IT WHEN…

you're sitting beside a sickbed, yours or someone else's, the nights are long and the medicine bottles line up.

PSALM 41

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer says those who care for the poor are blessed, and that the Lord sustains them on a sickbed. He asks for mercy and healing, though friends whisper and a close companion turns against him. He ends sure that God upholds him and sets him in his presence.

FOR YOUR KNOT

A sickbed is holy ground. Place one hand on the blanket, or on the patient's hand, and say verse three slowly. You aren't promising a cure; you're asking him to hold what you can't.

The LORD will sustain him on his sickbed, and restore him from his bed of illness.

PSALM 41:3 (WEB)

Lord, sustain the one in this bed. Hold what the medicine can't reach, and give strength to the hands that care. Have mercy on us both.



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PSALM 42

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

As the deer pants for water: when your soul is downcast.

READ IT WHEN…

sadness comes in the night and you long for something you can't name, a time, a person, a church full of voices.

PSALM 42

WHAT IT SAYS

A deer pants for water, and so the writer's soul pants for God. His tears are his food while people ask, "Where is your God?" He remembers when he led others in worship. Then he speaks to his own soul: why are you downcast? Hope in God. At night, God's song is with him.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Talk to your own soul the way the psalm does. Say: "Why are you sad? Hope in God." Say it kindly, as to a tired friend. Then hum one line of a hymn you know.

Why are you in despair, my soul? Why are you disturbed within me? Hope in God! For I shall still praise him for the saving help of his presence.

PSALM 42:5 (WEB)

Lord, my soul is thirsty tonight. I miss what used to be. Be near me, put a song in the dark, and help me hope in you again.



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PSALM 43

Send out your light and your truth to lead me home.

READ IT WHEN…

your spirit feels dark and confused and you can't find the way back to feeling at home with God.

PSALM 43

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks God to defend him against deceitful people and asks why he has been pushed away. Then he prays: send out your light and truth, let them lead me back to your holy hill. There he will go to God, his joy. He repeats to himself: hope in God.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Turn on one lamp, only one, and sit beside it. Ask for light for the next step, not the whole road. Light and truth are sent to lead us; they don't demand that we see everything.

Oh, send out your light and your truth. Let them lead me. Let them bring me to your holy hill, to your tents.

PSALM 43:3 (WEB)

Lord, I can't see my way. Send out your light and your truth, and let them lead me home. I will hope in you again.



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PSALM 44

Rouse yourself, Lord: for years when nothing seems to move.

READ IT WHEN…

years have gone by with nothing changing, and you wonder why God seems to be sleeping while your family suffers.

PSALM 44

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer remembers how God helped their ancestors, and says they never trusted their own sword. Yet now they are scattered and shamed, though they haven't forgotten God. He asks boldly, "Why do you sleep, Lord?" and begs him to rise and help, for the sake of his love.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You are allowed to say it: "Wake up." The psalm does. Faith isn't politeness. Say out loud what hasn't changed, then ask him to rise, for the sake of his love and not your deserving.

> *Rise up to help us. Redeem us for your loving kindness' sake.*
>
> PSALM 44:26 (WEB)

Lord, it's been years and I'm still asking. Rise up and help us. I haven't forgotten you; please don't forget us. Redeem us for your love's sake.



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45

PSALM 45

A wedding song: remember the day you said yes.

READ IT WHEN…

it's your anniversary, or an ordinary evening that is a good moment to remember the day you two said yes.

PSALM 45

WHAT IT SAYS

This is a song written for a royal wedding. The writer's heart overflows as he praises the king, who loves what is right, and then the bride, who is brought in gladness to his palace. The song promises that the king's name will be remembered for all generations.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Take out the wedding photo, or just close your eyes and picture the day. Tell your spouse, or tell God if they're gone, one thing you remember. Love that is remembered is often loved again.

I will make your name to be remembered in all generations. Therefore the peoples shall give you thanks forever and ever.

PSALM 45:17 (WEB)

Lord, thank you for the day we said yes. Help me remember it when we're tired and short with each other. Make our house glad again.



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PSALM 46

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

Be still, and know that I am God.

READ IT WHEN…

your mind won't stop racing at night, the same list of worries going around, and you need one command that fits in a breath.

PSALM 46

WHAT IT SAYS

God is a refuge and a present help in trouble, so we need not fear even if the mountains shake into the sea. A river makes God's city glad, and God is within it. Then the voice says, "Be still, and know that I am God." The Lord of Armies is with us.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Breathe in on "Be still," and out on "and know that I am God." Do it seven times, slowly, in bed. If a worry returns, begin again. You don't have to solve the night. You only have to be still.

> *Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations. I will be exalted on the earth.*
>
> PSALM 46:10 (WEB)

Lord, I'm going to be still, because you said to. Be my refuge tonight, and a present help for everything I can't fix by morning.



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PSALM 47

Clap your hands: a joyful note for a heavy week.

READ IT WHEN…

the week has been heavy and you've nearly forgotten what joy sounds like, and you want to make a small noise of thanks.

PSALM 47

WHAT IT SAYS

Clap your hands, all you peoples, and shout to God with joy! He is the great King over all the earth. The psalm invites everyone to sing praises with understanding, because God reigns on his holy throne and the shields of the earth belong to him.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Clap three times, out loud, alone in your kitchen. It will feel silly for a second. Then say, "You are king over this week too." Praise lifts heavy things by changing who you're looking at.

> *Oh clap your hands, all you nations. Shout to God with the voice of triumph!*
>
> PSALM 47:1 (WEB)

Lord, it's been a heavy week, and I'm clapping anyway. You are king over all the earth, and over this house too. Thank you.



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48

PSALM 48

Walk around his city in your mind and count its towers.

READ IT WHEN…

you can't leave the house, or can't find the words to pray, and you want to walk through something strong and beautiful in your mind.

PSALM 48

WHAT IT SAYS

This is a walking psalm. The writer praises the city of God, a refuge for those inside. He tells us to walk around it, count its towers and look at its walls, so we can tell the next generation. At the end: this God is our God forever, our guide even to death.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Take a slow walk through your own memory. Think of the strongest, most faithful places in your life, your first church, your mother's kitchen, a friend's porch, and count them like towers. Then tell a grandchild about one.

For this God is our God forever and ever. He will be our guide even to death.

PSALM 48:14 (WEB)

Lord, I walk through all you have built around me, and I count it. You've been a refuge. Be my guide, today and at the end.



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49

PSALM 49

Money cannot redeem a life: read it when prices frighten you.

READ IT WHEN…

prices frighten you at the checkout, or you feel small next to people with big houses and bigger bank accounts.

PSALM 49

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer speaks to rich and poor alike. Why fear in bad days, he asks. Those who trust in their riches cannot buy back even a brother's life; the price is too high. The wealthy die and leave their money to others. But God will redeem his soul, so don't fear when someone gets rich.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Money is a tool, not a rock. Today, choose one thing no one can sell you, a handshake, a hymn, a grandchild's laugh, and give thanks for it first. Then open the bills with a calmer heart.

> *Don’t be afraid when a man is made rich, when the glory of his house is increased;*
>
> PSALM 49:16 (WEB)

Lord, money can't redeem a single hour of my life, but you can. When prices frighten me, remind me whom I belong to.



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PSALM 50

Offer thanks as your sacrifice and keep your vows.

READ IT WHEN…

you made God a promise in a hard hour and let it slide, or want to say thanks in a way that costs something.

PSALM 50

WHAT IT SAYS

God says he doesn't need animal offerings; every animal and hill already belongs to him. What he wants is thanks and promises kept. Call on him in the day of trouble, he says, and he will rescue you. He also warns people who recite his words but live dishonestly.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Remember one promise you made to God in a hard hour, a visit, a prayer, a bit of help for someone. Keep it this week, or renew it. Then say a plain thank-you with nothing asked. That's the gift he says he wants.

> *Offer to God the sacrifice of thanksgiving. Pay your vows to the Most High.*
>
> PSALM 50:14 (WEB)

Lord, I remember what I promised you. I'm making it good, little by little. Accept my thanks as the gift I bring, because it's what I have.



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PSALM 51

Create in me a clean heart: the great prayer of repentance.

READ IT WHEN...

you have done something you wish you could undo, and you want to start over with a clean heart, not just a clean record.

WHAT IT SAYS

This is the great prayer of someone who has done wrong and knows it. He asks for mercy, to be washed clean, and for a new heart and a steady spirit. He asks not to be thrown from God's presence.He says God wants a broken, humble heart more than gifts.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say verse ten aloud, slowly, three times. Then name the wrong in one honest sentence, no excuses. After that, do one thing to put it right, if you can. A clean heart starts with the truth.

Create in me a clean heart, O God. Renew a right spirit within me.

PSALM 51:10 (WEB)

Lord, create in me a clean heart. I won't make excuses. Wash me, renew a steady spirit in me, and don't send me away from you.



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52

PSALM 52

The liar will fall; I am like a green olive tree in his house.

READ IT WHEN…

someone at work told a lie about you, or got ahead by cheating, and you're tempted to answer with a lie of your own.

PSALM 52

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer speaks to a powerful man whose tongue plots like a sharp razor and loves lies more than truth. He says God will bring such a man down. By contrast, the writer is like a green olive tree in God's house, trusting God's kindness forever, and he gives thanks.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Don't answer a lie with a lie.
Write the true version in one calm line, and keep it in your pocket in case you need it.
Then do your work well today.
Roots show in ordinary hours.

But as for me, I am like a green olive tree in God's house. I trust in God's loving kindness forever and ever.

PSALM 52:8 (WEB)

Lord, someone has lied. Keep me from lying back. Make me like a green olive tree in your house, rooted in your kindness and quiet in my work.



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PSALM 53

A prayer when it looks as if God has stopped seeing.

READ IT WHEN…

it looks as if God has stopped seeing, and you feel as though nobody around you cares about right or wrong anymore.

WHAT IT SAYS

The psalm opens with a hard picture: people say in their hearts there is no God, and corruption is everywhere. But God looks down from heaven to see if anyone understands and seeks him. It ends with a longing that God would bring his people back and give them joy.

FOR YOUR KNOT

When it looks like nobody's watching, remember he is. Do one small hidden good deed today, the kind no one will thank you for, such as paying for the next person's coffee or fixing the neighbor's gate. He sees it even if no one else does.

God looks down from heaven on the children of men, to see if there are any who understood, who seek after God.

PSALM 53:2 (WEB)

Lord, the world looks careless today. But you look down and you see. Let me be one who seeks you, even when nobody notices.



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PSALM 54

God is my helper: for the moment you feel alone and threatened.

READ IT WHEN…

you feel alone and threatened, a stranger at the door, a rough street, a voice on the phone, and you need help right now.

PSALM 54

WHAT IT SAYS

It's a short, urgent prayer. The writer says strangers have risen up against him and violent people want his life. He asks God to save him and hear his prayer. Then he declares: God is my helper, the one who sustains my soul. He promises thanks, because God has delivered him from trouble.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Do the sensible thing first: lock the door, call someone. Then say verse four, just once, out loud. Prayer and a phone call go together. God is your helper, and so is the neighbor who answers.

Behold, God is my helper. The Lord is the one who sustains my soul.

PSALM 54:4 (WEB)

Lord, I feel alone and exposed. Be my helper right now, and sustain my soul. Send me a sensible friend, and keep me calm.



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55

PSALM 55

FOR THE NIGHT

"It was you, my companion": cast your burden on the Lord.

READ IT WHEN…

someone close, a spouse, a friend, a brother, has broken your trust, and it hurts more because you once shared bread.

PSALM 55

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer is afraid and wishes he had wings like a dove to fly away. Then he says it wasn't an enemy who hurt him; it was his close friend, whose words were smooth as butter but whose heart was war. He prays morning, noon and evening: cast your burden on the Lord.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Betrayal by someone close hurts because it was close. Don't hurry to forgive or to punish tonight. Say who it was, plainly, and name what they broke. Then hand it over: "Lord, I cast this on you."

> *Cast your burden on the LORD and he will sustain you. He will never allow the righteous to be moved.*
>
> PSALM 55:22 (WEB)

Lord, it was someone I trusted. I can't carry this tonight. I cast it on you, the whole weight, and ask you to sustain me until morning.



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56

PSALM 56

FOR THE NIGHT

You keep my tears in your bottle: nothing I cried was wasted.

READ IT WHEN…

you've cried in the dark again and wonder whether it matters to anyone at all that you did.

PSALM 56

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer is afraid and under attack all day, with people twisting his words. He says, "When I am afraid, I will put my trust in you." Then comes the line: God counts his wanderings and keeps his tears in a bottle. In the end he says he knows God is for him.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Tears are not wasted. Let them come tonight. When you are done, wash your face and say: "You are counting these." Then rest. Someone is keeping every one of them.

You count my wanderings. You put my tears into your container. Aren't they in your book?

PSALM 56:8 (WEB)

Lord, you keep my tears in your bottle and count each one. I'm not crying alone. When I'm afraid, I will put my trust in you.



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PSALM 57

FOR THE NIGHT

In the shadow of your wings I take refuge.

READ IT WHEN…

you need somewhere safe to hide until the trouble passes, and you can't see how long it will take.

PSALM 57

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks for mercy twice and takes refuge in the shadow of God's wings until the disaster is over. He is surrounded by people whose tongues are sharp as swords, yet his heart is steady, and he promises to sing and wake up the dawn. God's love reaches to the heavens.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Hide for a while without shame. Go to the quietest room, cover yourself with a blanket, and say verse one. Hiding in God is not running away; it's getting out of the rain until the storm has passed.

Be merciful to me, God, be merciful to me, for my soul takes refuge in you. Yes, in the shadow of your wings, I will take refuge, until disaster has passed.

PSALM 57:1 (WEB)

Lord, be merciful to me. I'm taking refuge under your wings until this storm passes. Keep my heart steady, and wake me with the dawn.



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PSALM 58

There is a God who judges the earth.

READ IT WHEN…

a boss, a landlord, an official or a judge has treated you or someone weak unfairly, and nobody seems able to stop it.

PSALM 58

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer is angry at rulers who talk about justice but plot injustice. In strong language he asks God to stop them. In the end he says people will see that the righteous are rewarded, and that there is a God who judges the earth.

FOR YOUR KNOT

It's all right to be angry at injustice; the psalm is. But let God hold the sword. Do the one lawful thing in front of you today: write the letter, make the call, tell the truth to the person who needs it.

> *so that men shall say, "Most certainly there is a reward for the righteous. Most certainly there is a God who judges the earth.*
>
> PSALM 58:11 (WEB)

Lord, I'm angry at what's unjust. I leave the sword to you. Show me the one honest step I can take, and be the Judge of the earth.



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PSALM 59

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

Guard me through the night; I will sing of your strength at dawn.

READ IT WHEN…

fear comes with the dark, steps outside, noises in the house, memories that prowl, and you want a guard until morning.

PSALM 59

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks God to guard him from people lying in wait for him. They come back every evening, prowling like dogs around the city. He says God is his strength and his high tower. He promises that in the morning he will sing aloud of God's strength and love.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Make the night small. Check the door once, turn on a night light, and say, "You are my high tower." Then think ahead to the morning song. Fear belongs to the night; the song belongs to you at dawn.

But I will sing of your strength. Yes, I will sing aloud of your loving kindness in the morning. For you have been my high tower, a refuge in the day of my distress.

PSALM 59:16 (WEB)

Lord, guard me through this night. You are my high tower. Let me sleep, and when the morning comes, let me sing of your strength.



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PSALM 60

You have rejected us: give us help against the trouble.

READ IT WHEN…

something you built has fallen apart, a friendship, your savings, the peace of your family, and you're standing in the pieces not knowing where to start.

PSALM 60

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer says God has broken the people down, made the land shake and given them hard things. He asks God to restore them and mend what is cracked. He asks for help against the enemy, because human help is empty. In the end he says that with God they will act with courage.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Mend one crack today, not the whole wall. Pick the smallest broken thing, a missed call, a debt, a drawer, and repair it. Ask God for help, and take it from the people he sends.

> *Give us help against the adversary, for the help of man is vain.*
>
> PSALM 60:11 (WEB)

Lord, so much has shaken and cracked. Restore us, and mend what is broken. Human help is thin; give us yours, and make us brave.



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PSALM 61

From the end of the earth I call: lead me to the rock.

READ IT WHEN…

you are far from home, or far from the people who matter, and your heart is too full to find the words.

PSALM 61

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer cries from the end of the earth, when his heart is overwhelmed, and asks to be led to a rock higher than himself. He says God has been his refuge and strong tower. He longs to live in God's tent under his wings, and promises to keep his vows daily.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Distance is a knot too. If you are far from family, send one short message today, just "thinking of you." If they are far from you, say each name to God before you sleep. Distance hurts, but not him.

> *From the end of the earth, I will call to you when my heart is overwhelmed. Lead me to the rock that is higher than I.*
>
> PSALM 61:2 (WEB)

Lord, from this far-off place I call to you. My heart is overwhelmed. Lead me to the rock that is higher than I, and bring me home.



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PSALM 62

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

For God alone my soul waits in silence.

READ IT WHEN…

you have nothing left to say, and you're too tired to argue with God or with anybody else.

PSALM 62

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer says his soul waits in silence for God alone: God is his rock, his salvation and his fortress, so he will not be greatly shaken. He notes that people bless with their mouths and curse inside. So he urges everyone to trust God at all times and pour out the heart.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Sit for five minutes without asking for anything. When your mind wanders, bring it back to the verse: "My soul rests in God alone." When the five minutes are up, say one honest sentence from the heart, and stop.

My soul rests in God alone. My salvation is from him.

PSALM 62:1 (WEB)

Lord, I have no words tonight. My soul waits in silence for you alone. Be my rock and my fortress, and let me rest.



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63

PSALM 63

FOR THE NIGHT

"On my bed I remember you in the watches of the night."

READ IT WHEN…

you wake at two or three and can't get back to sleep, and you wonder if the hour can be used for something good.

PSALM 63

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer is thirsty for God, in a dry and weary land. He says God's love is better than life. He remembers God on his bed and thinks about him in the night watches. His soul stays close to God, and God's right hand holds him up.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Don't fight the waking hour. Treat it as an appointment. Sit up, sip some water, and say the name of God slowly, ten times. Remember one way he has helped you. Then lie back down.

> *when I remember you on my bed, and think about you in the night watches.*
>
> PSALM 63:6 (WEB)

Lord, I'm awake, so I'm coming to you. Your love is better than sleep. Hold me up in these night watches, and send me back to rest.



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64

PSALM 64

FOR THE NIGHT

Hide me from the whisperers: they will be struck by their own words.

READ IT WHEN…

you know people are whispering about you, and the rumor has you tossing in the dark more than the truth would.

PSALM 64

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks God to hide him from people who sharpen their tongues like swords and aim deadly words in secret. They say, "Who will see?" But God sees, and their own words will turn against them. In the end the upright will be glad and take refuge in God.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You can't stop a whisper, but you can stop listening to it at midnight. Say, "Lord, you see it," and let the matter wait for daylight. Then speak to one honest person you trust.

Hear my voice, God, in my complaint. Preserve my life from fear of the enemy.

PSALM 64:1 (WEB)

Lord, hide me from the whisperers. You see what they say in the dark. Preserve my life from fear, and let me sleep.



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65

PSALM 65

You crown the year with your bounty: pray it over an empty pantry.

READ IT WHEN…

the pantry is nearly empty and payday is far, and you need to remember the God who fills the fields.

PSALM 65

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer praises God who hears prayer. He describes how God waters the earth, softens the soil with showers and blesses the crops. Then comes the line: you crown the year with your bounty, and your carts overflow. The pastures are full of flocks and the valleys shout for joy.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Open the pantry or the fridge and name what is there, down to the last can, and thank God for each thing. Then pray verse eleven over the empty shelf. Provision often starts with noticing.

> *You crown the year with your bounty. Your carts overflow with abundance.*
>
> PSALM 65:11 (WEB)

Lord, you crown the year with your bounty. Look at my shelves. Provide what we need this week, and teach me to give thanks for what is here.



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66

PSALM 66

Come and hear what he has done for my soul.

READ IT WHEN…

the worst is over and you want to tell someone, anyone, what God did for you in the middle of it.

PSALM 66

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer calls everyone to shout to God. He remembers a hard road: tested like silver, led into prison, through fire and water, and brought out into a place of abundance. Then he says: come and hear what he has done for my soul. God has listened to his prayer.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Tell someone your story this week, a grandchild, a neighbor, a friend at church. Keep it short: what was hard, what happened, what you learned. Telling it is how your trial becomes someone else's gift.

Come and hear, all you who fear God. I will declare what he has done for my soul.

PSALM 66:16 (WEB)

Lord, you brought me through fire and water. I won't keep quiet about it. Give me the words, and someone to hear them.



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67

PSALM 67

May God be gracious to us and bless us: a family blessing.

READ IT WHEN…

the family is gathered, or you are blessing a child at the door, and you want a short blessing to say over them.

PSALM 67

WHAT IT SAYS

This short psalm asks God to be gracious, to bless us and let his face shine on us. It hopes that all peoples will know his way and praise him. It closes in thanks: the earth has yielded its harvest, and God will bless us.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say verse one over each person in your family, by name, with a hand on a shoulder or just in your prayers. Short blessings are easy to say and hard to forget.

> *May God be merciful to us, bless us, and cause his face to shine on us. Selah.*
>
> PSALM 67:1 (WEB)

Lord, be gracious to my family and bless each of us. Let your face shine on the ones I love, near and far.



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68

PSALM 68

A father to the fatherless, a defender of widows.

READ IT WHEN…

you are widowed or living alone and the house is too quiet, and the empty chair is the loudest thing in the room.

PSALM 68

WHAT IT SAYS

Most of this long psalm is a victory song. In the middle is the line that matters here: God is a father to the fatherless and a defender of widows, and he sets the lonely in families. Later it says God daily bears our burdens, and gives strength and power to his people.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Loneliness is a knot, and God ties people to people. Today make one small call or visit, to a neighbor, a parish group, a niece. Say "sets the lonely in families," and then go find one.

> *A father of the fatherless, and a defender of the widows, is God in his holy habitation.*
>
> PSALM 68:5 (WEB)

Lord, you defend widows and set the lonely in families. The house is quiet tonight. Be near, and send someone to my door.



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69

PSALM 69

The waters have come up to my neck: the prayer of the overwhelmed.

READ IT WHEN…

debt has risen to your neck and the mail frightens you, and you cannot see the bottom or the shore.

WHAT IT SAYS

The waters come up to the writer's neck. He sinks in deep mire with no foothold, tired of crying, with a dry throat. His enemies are many, and even his family has turned away. He asks God not to let him sink, and to draw near. He ends sure that God hears the needy.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Gather the bills in one pile, put your hand on them, and read the first verse aloud. Then call one creditor or one trusted friend. A foothold, however small, beats sinking in silence.

> *Save me, God, for the waters have come up to my neck!*
>
> PSALM 69:1 (WEB)

Lord, the waters are up to my neck. Don't let me sink. Give me a foothold today, and the courage to open the envelopes.



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70

PSALM 70

Hurry, Lord, to help me: the shortest prayer for the longest week.

READ IT WHEN…

the need can't wait, the rent, the prescription, the car repair, and you only have breath for one short prayer.

PSALM 70

WHAT IT SAYS

This is among the shortest prayers in the book. The writer cries for God to hurry and come quickly to help. He says he is poor and needy. He asks that those who seek God rejoice, and ends: you are my help and my deliverer, Lord, don't delay.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say it as it is, in a few words: "Lord, hurry. I need help." Then do the next practical thing in front of you, ask the neighbor, call the office. Short prayers and small actions go together.

But I am poor and needy.
Come to me quickly, God. You
are my help and my deliverer.
LORD, don't delay.

PSALM 70:5 (WEB)

Lord, hurry to help me. I am poor and needy. You are my help and my deliverer, so please, my God, don't delay.



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71

PSALM 71

Do not cast me away in my old age.

READ IT WHEN…

your strength is not what it was, and you wonder if you're still needed, or if anyone has noticed you slowing down.

PSALM 71

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer has trusted God since his youth and has praised him all his life. Now in old age, with his strength failing, he prays: don't reject me, don't forsake me. He says he will go on hoping and telling the next generation about God's power, even when he is old and gray-haired.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Your years are not a burden to him. This week, teach one thing to someone younger: a recipe, a prayer, how you got through a hard year. You have more to give than you think.

> *Don’t reject me in my old age. Don’t forsake me when my strength fails.*
>
> PSALM 71:9 (WEB)

Lord, don't cast me aside now that I'm old. You've been my hope since I was young. Use my years for someone else's good.



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PSALM 72

A king who defends the needy: pray for the one with less than you.

READ IT WHEN…

you have a little more than someone you know, and you wonder what you owe them, or you simply want to pray for people who have less.

PSALM 72

WHAT IT SAYS

This is a prayer for a just king. The writer asks that he rule with righteousness, defend the poor and save the children of the needy. His rule brings peace. He will deliver the needy who cry for help and pity the poor, and their lives will be precious to him.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Pray for one person with less than you this week, by name, then do one small thing: a coat, a casserole, a phone call. You may be the answer to someone's prayer.

> *For he will deliver the needy when he cries; the poor, who has no helper. He will have pity on the poor and needy. He will save the souls of the needy.*
>
> PSALM 72:12-13 (WEB)

Lord, defend the poor and the forgotten. Bless the one I'm thinking of, and let my hands be part of your answer.



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PSALM 73

Why do the wicked prosper? Then you enter his presence and see.

READ IT WHEN…

someone who treated you badly seems to be doing fine, and you can't shake the feeling that life isn't fair.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer almost lost his footing, envying proud people who seemed to prosper without trouble. He tried to understand and it hurt, until he went into God's sanctuary and saw the bigger picture. He admits his bitterness, and says, "I am continually with you. You have held my right hand."

FOR YOUR KNOT

Bring the bitter comparison into prayer. Sit quietly, even in your own chair, and say the name of the person you envy. Then add, "Whom do I have but you?" Going in to God is what changed the writer's mind.

> *Nevertheless, I am continually with you. You have held my right hand.*
>
> PSALM 73:23 (WEB)

Lord, I let envy eat at me. I'm sorry. I am with you, and you hold my hand. Take the bitterness and leave me peace.



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74

PSALM 74

Remember your people: for when everything familiar is torn down.

READ IT WHEN…

everything familiar has been torn down, the church closed, the old neighborhood gone, the friends moved away, and you feel forsaken.

PSALM 74

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer weeps over a sanctuary that has been burned and broken, and asks why God seems to have rejected his people. He remembers God as King of old, who divided the sea and made the day and the night. He then asks God to remember his people and the poor.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Make a short list of what is gone, and then of what God has already carried you through. Ask him to "remember." Then keep one small familiar thing in your day: a hymn, a cup, a chair.

> *Don't deliver the soul of your dove to wild beasts. Don't forget the life of your poor forever.*
>
> PSALM 74:19 (WEB)

Lord, so much that was familiar is gone. Remember your people, and remember me. You made the day and the night. Hold me in both.



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PSALM 75

It is God who lifts up and who brings down.

READ IT WHEN…

someone else got the promotion you were waiting for, or you finally got your own and feel tempted to look down on the ones who didn't.

PSALM 75

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer gives thanks that God's name is near. God says he will judge fairly and hold the pillars of the earth steady. He tells the proud not to boast. Promotion comes not from the east, the west or the south, but from God, who puts one down and lifts another up.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Whether you're passed over or promoted, do today's work as if God signs the pay. Thank a coworker who helped you, out loud. Promotion fades; gratitude doesn't.

> *But God is the judge. He puts down one, and lifts up another.*
>
> PSALM 75:7 (WEB)

Lord, you are the one who lifts up and brings down. Keep me humble when I'm lifted, and steady when I'm passed over. Let me do my work for you.



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PSALM 76

Even human anger ends up praising him: a psalm for steadying fear.

READ IT WHEN…

the news, or a loud voice in your own family, has left your stomach in a knot and your hands unsteady.

WHAT IT SAYS

This psalm sings about a God who is known and feared, who broke the weapons of war and silenced the earth when he rose up to save the afflicted. Even human anger, it says, ends up serving his praise. The frightened are told to keep their promises to him.

FOR YOUR KNOT

The loudest voice in the room is not the last voice. Name the one that frightens you, and tell God plainly that he is bigger than that person's temper.

> *Surely the wrath of man praises you. The survivors of your wrath are restrained.*
>
> PSALM 76:10 (WEB)

Lord, there's a voice in my house I can't quiet. Be bigger than it today, and steady my hands at the table until it passes.



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77

PSALM 77

FOR THE NIGHT

"I cry aloud to God": then remember the old days. A psalm for 3 a.m.

READ IT WHEN…

you're lying in the dark with your hand out on the cold side of the bed, too tired to sleep and too rattled to pray in whole sentences.

WHAT IT SAYS

FOR YOUR KNOT

You don't have to answer the 3 a.m. questions. You only have to stop carrying them alone. Say the worst one out loud, the way he did. Then think of one time you were carried, a hospital hallway, a funeral, a bad winter. Let that memory be your pillow.

The writer cries out at night and refuses to be comforted. Then he asks the questions most of us are scared to ask: Has God's kindness run dry? Has he forgotten how to be gracious? What turns him is not an answer. He decides to remember what God did in the old days, and that memory is enough to steady him until morning.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You don't have to answer the 3 a.m. questions. You only have to stop carrying them alone. Say the worst one out loud, the way he did. Then think of one time you were carried, a hospital hallway, a funeral, a bad winter. Let that memory be your pillow.

> *My cry goes to God! Indeed, I cry to God for help, and for him to listen to me.*
>
> PSALM 77:1 (WEB)

Lord, I can't sleep and I can't stop asking why. Hear me anyway. Remind me of one time you carried me, and let me rest on that.



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78

PSALM 78

Tell your children what God has done: a grandparent's psalm.

READ IT WHEN…

a grandchild is across the table from you, and you wonder whether anything you believe will still be standing after you're gone.

WHAT IT SAYS

FOR YOUR KNOT

Nobody can make a child believe. You can tell the story, and the story is the one thing they can't get from a screen. Pick one time God came through for you, keep it under two minutes, and tell it this week, at the table or on the phone.

This psalm tells a long story on purpose, so that children will know it. What the parents learned about God has to be handed down, so the next generation puts its hope in him and doesn't forget what he did. It's honest, too: earlier generations often forgot, and the psalm tells that part anyway.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Nobody can make a child believe. You can tell the story, and the story is the one thing they can't get from a screen. Pick one time God came through for you, keep it under two minutes, and tell it this week, at the table or on the phone.

We will not hide them from their children, telling to the generation to come the praises of the LORD, his strength, and his wondrous deeds that he has done.

PSALM 78:4 (WEB)

Lord, give me the right words and the right moment to tell my grandchildren what you've done for me. Plant it in them, and don't let them lose it.



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PSALM 79

Help us, God of our salvation, and forgive our sins.

READ IT WHEN…

something your family built has fallen apart, and part of you knows you had a hand in it.

PSALM 79

WHAT IT SAYS

This is the cry after a terrible loss. The people describe the ruin and the shame, and then they do the hard thing: they ask God to forgive their sins, not just to fix their enemies. They ask for help for the sake of his name, and promise to thank him in every generation to come.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Mercy is asked for, not earned. Think of the old family wrong that nobody talks about, the one you inherited or helped along. Name it to God in one plain sentence, and ask him to deal gently with it before you ask for anything else.

Help us, God of our salvation,
for the glory of your name.
Deliver us, and forgive our sins,
for your name's sake.

PSALM 79:9 (WEB)

God of my salvation, help us. Forgive what we did, and what was done long before I was born. Meet this family with mercy, and I will thank you.



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PSALM 80

Turn us again, God: let your face shine, and we will be saved.

READ IT WHEN…

someone you love has turned away from the family, you've run out of arguments, and all you can do now is ask for them to be turned back.

WHAT IT SAYS

FOR YOUR KNOT

You can't turn another person's heart. You can say the refrain for them. Use their name: "Turn Michael again. Let your face shine on him." Say it once in the morning and once at night, and say it for yourself too, because you're a little lost as well.

A scattered people ask the Shepherd to shine his face on them again. The same refrain comes three times, a little stronger each time: turn us again, and we will be saved. The psalm pictures them as a vine that was planted well and then torn down, and it asks God to look at it and come back to it.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You can't turn another person's heart. You can say the refrain for them. Use their name: "Turn Michael again. Let your face shine on him." Say it once in the morning and once at night, and say it for yourself too, because you're a little lost as well.

> *Turn us again, God. Cause your face to shine, and we will be saved.*
>
> PSALM 80:3 (WEB)

Shepherd, turn us again. Let your face shine on the one whose name I'm holding, and on me. Bring us home.



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PSALM 81

Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it.

READ IT WHEN…

you're worn out from asking, and you've half forgotten that the door was never locked on you.

PSALM 81

WHAT IT SAYS

It starts as a festival song, and then God himself speaks. He reminds his people that he freed them and answered them when they called. Then comes the line: open your mouth wide and I will fill it. He grieves that they wouldn't listen, and says he would have fed them with the finest wheat.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Most of us ask for the polite thing. Ask for the real one, the thing you'd say if you knew he wouldn't be annoyed. Then do the part we skip: sit still for a full minute and listen.

I am the LORD, your God, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt. Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it.

PSALM 81:10 (WEB)

Lord, I'm coming with my mouth open and my hands empty. Give me what I really need today, and help me be quiet enough to hear you.



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82

PSALM 82

Defend the weak and the fatherless: a psalm for when you've seen someone treated unfairly.

READ IT WHEN…

you saw a neighbor, a coworker or a widow down the street treated unfairly this week, and you went home not knowing what you could do about it.

PSALM 82

WHAT IT SAYS

God stands in the middle of the powerful and asks how long they will go on judging unjustly. He tells them to defend the weak and the fatherless and to rescue the needy from the hand of the wicked. The psalm ends with a plea: rise up, God, and judge the earth, because it all belongs to you.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Fairness starts small and close to home. Think of one person near you who has less power than you do. Do one thing for them before supper: a ride to the pharmacy, a phone call, one sentence in their favor where they can't hear it.

Defend the weak, the poor, and the fatherless. Maintain the rights of the poor and oppressed.

PSALM 82:3 (WEB)

Lord, show me who near me is being treated unfairly. Give me the courage to stand beside them, and the good sense to do it kindly.



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83

PSALM 83

God, do not keep silent: for when it feels like everyone is against you.

READ IT WHEN…

it feels like everyone quietly agreed against you, and you can't tell who is still on your side.

PSALM 83

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer begs God not to stay silent. A whole crowd of enemies has joined together against God's people, and the psalm names them one by one, as if reading out a list. He asks God to deal with them, so that they will finally know he alone is the Most High over all the earth.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You can tell God "they're all against me" without cleaning it up first. He can take it, and he already knows who's in the room. Then name one person who hasn't left you, one, and thank him for that person by name.

> *God, don’t keep silent. Don’t keep silent, and don’t be still, God.*
>
> PSALM 83:1 (WEB)

God, don't be silent. You see who is against me and who is still beside me. Stay close, and let me know you're awake.



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PSALM 84

How lovely is your dwelling place: for anyone who misses home.

READ IT WHEN…

you miss home, the real one, with the kitchen and the pew and the voices that are gone, more than you can say to anyone.

PSALM 84

WHAT IT SAYS

A traveler on the road to God's house sings about how lovely it is. Even the sparrow has found a home there, and the swallow a nest for her young. The people who walk through the Valley of Weeping turn it into a place of springs, and they go from strength to strength until they arrive.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Homesickness is already a prayer. Don't try to talk yourself out of it. Let the ache say what it wants to say, and tell God what you miss in specifics: the smell of a kitchen, a man's voice in the hall. You're on the road home, not lost.

> *My soul longs, and even faints for the courts of the LORD. My heart and my flesh cry out for the living God.*
>
> PSALM 84:2 (WEB)

Lord, I miss home, and some of it is gone for good. Be my home today. Make this valley a place with a little water in it.



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PSALM 85

Mercy and truth meet; righteousness and peace kiss.

READ IT WHEN…

two people in one house have stopped fighting but haven't started talking, and somebody has to go first.

PSALM 85

WHAT IT SAYS

The people remember that God has forgiven them before, and they ask him to turn toward them again. The writer then stops and listens for what God will say, and what he hears is peace. The picture he gives is lovely: mercy and truth meet, and righteousness and peace kiss each other.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Peace in a marriage is two things meeting, not one person winning. Say the true thing and the kind thing in the same sentence today, such as "I was hurt, and I still want us to be all right." Don't wait for the other person to go first.

> *Mercy and truth meet together. Righteousness and peace have kissed each other.*
>
> PSALM 85:10 (WEB)

Lord, let mercy and truth meet in my house. Help me say the true thing and the kind thing together, and help us each really hear the other.



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PSALM 86

Bow down your ear, Lord, for I am poor and needy.

READ IT WHEN…

the account is nearly empty, you feel too small to ask for anything, and you ask anyway.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer says it flat out: I am poor and needy. He doesn't dress it up. He asks God to listen, to be merciful and to bring joy to his soul, because he trusts that God is good and ready to forgive. He says he will call on him in the day of trouble, because he knows he'll be answered.

FOR YOUR KNOT

"I am poor and needy" is how a prayer begins, not how it ends. Say it to God without shame. Then ask for the next step with the money, not the whole sum: which bill first, which call to make.

Hear, LORD, and answer me,
for I am poor and needy.

PSALM 86:1 (WEB)

Lord, I'm short, and you know the number. Bow down your ear to me. Show me one next step with the bills, and spare me the shame.



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PSALM 87

This one was born there: a psalm for those who feel they belong nowhere.

READ IT WHEN…

you feel you belong nowhere, in a new town, a new church, or a house full of people from another world.

PSALM 87

WHAT IT SAYS

A short song about the city God loves. God himself writes up a list of the peoples, even ones who were once enemies, and says of each one: this one was born there. Everybody gets a place on the roll. The singers and the dancers end with the words, "All my springs are in you."

FOR YOUR KNOT

God keeps the register, not the neighbors. Say your own name to him today as if he were writing it in the book, because the psalm says he is. Then do it for someone else: learn one new person's name this week and use it.

> *the LORD will count, when he writes up the peoples, "This one was born there." Selah.*
>
> PSALM 87:6 (WEB)

Lord, write my name where I belong. Where I feel like a stranger, let me know I'm counted, and let me be kind to another stranger.



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PSALM 88

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

The one psalm with no light at the end. He still hears it.

READ IT WHEN…

there is no light at the end of the night and you can't pretend there is. This psalm won't pretend either.

WHAT IT SAYS

This is the only psalm that ends in darkness. The writer says he has cried out day and night, that his friends have been taken from him, that he feels close to the grave. He never says it got better. But every line is still spoken to God, and by the morning he is still praying.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Honest prayer doesn't have to end in comfort. If tonight is only dark, say so, in those words, and don't add a happy line to please anyone. Praying in the dark still counts as praying. If it stays this dark for days, tell a doctor or a pastor too.

> *Let my prayer enter into your presence. Turn your ear to my cry.*
>
> PSALM 88:2 (WEB)

Lord, I have nothing bright to say. Here is the dark, just as it is. Turn your ear to me, and stay in the room.



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PSALM 89

I will sing of his love forever: a promise for generations.

READ IT WHEN…

you lie awake wondering what will become of your children's children, and you need a promise bigger than anything you can give them.

WHAT IT SAYS

FOR YOUR KNOT

You can't hold the future for them. Hold the promise instead. Go down the list of your children and grandchildren, say each name, and after each one say, "Your love stands firm." It takes two minutes and it covers generations.

A song about God's faithful love and the promise he made to a king's family: your descendants will last, and your throne will stand through all generations. The writer praises God for ruling the sea and calming its waves. Later the psalm admits that the promise can look broken, and still it ends in blessing.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You can't hold the future for them. Hold the promise instead. Go down the list of your children and grandchildren, say each name, and after each one say, "Your love stands firm." It takes two minutes and it covers generations.

I will sing of the loving kindness of the LORD forever. With my mouth, I will make known your faithfulness to all generations.

PSALM 89:1 (WEB)

Lord, I can't see what's coming for my family. Hold each one as you promised, and let your love stand firm in every generation after me.



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PSALM 90

Teach us to count our days so that we gain a wise heart.

READ IT WHEN…

a birthday, a funeral, or a long wait at the doctor's office has just reminded you how fast the days go.

PSALM 90

WHAT IT SAYS

Moses prays that God has been our home in every generation, while our years pass like grass that is green in the morning and dry by evening. He asks God to teach us to count our days, to satisfy us each morning with his love, and to bless the work of our hands.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Counting your days isn't gloom, it's choosing. Pick the one thing you will not leave for later, an apology, a visit, a call to a brother you haven't spoken to, and do it this week. Then ask for the love to satisfy you in the morning, before you reach for the phone.

> *So teach us to count our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom.*
>
> PSALM 90:12 (WEB)

Lord, teach me to count my days. Let me spend today on what matters, and let your love satisfy me before I reach for anything else.



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PSALM 91

FOR THE NIGHT

Under his wings you will not fear the terror of the night.

READ IT WHEN…

something in the dark frightens you, a noise on the stairs, a thought, an old memory, and you need a roof over your head.

WHAT IT SAYS

The psalm describes a person who lives in God's shelter. His faithfulness is a shield, and he covers them like a bird with its feathers. The writer names the terrors of the night and the dangers of the day and says there is no need to be afraid of any of them. At the end God himself speaks: "I will be with him in trouble."

FOR YOUR KNOT

You're not asked to be brave alone. Say the word "refuge" out loud once. Hearing yourself say it moves the fear one step back from the bed. Then check the lock one time, only one, and leave the rest of the house to him.

He will cover you with his feathers. Under his wings you will take refuge. His faithfulness is your shield and rampart.

PSALM 91:4 (WEB)

Lord, be my roof tonight. Under your wings I'll stop listening for every sound. Keep this house, and let me sleep until morning.



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PSALM 92

Still bearing fruit in old age, fresh and green.

READ IT WHEN…

you feel old and used up, and you quietly wonder whether you still have anything left to give.

WHAT IT SAYS

It is good to thank God in the morning for his love and every night for his faithfulness. The writer says the righteous will flourish like a palm tree, planted in God's house. They will still produce fruit in old age, full of sap and green, and they'll still be saying that God is upright.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Old age isn't the end of fruit. Give something away today that only you can give: your mother's recipe, the story of how you met, a kind word on the phone to someone younger. Do it before the kettle boils.

> *They will still produce fruit in old age. They will be full of sap and green,*
>
> PSALM 92:14 (WEB)

Lord, I'm not finished. Use these hands and this voice today. Keep me green, and let me be of use to someone.



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PSALM 93

The floods lift up their voice, but he is mightier.

READ IT WHEN…

everything feels like rising water, the bills, the news, a worry about one of the kids, and you need something that doesn't move.

PSALM 93

WHAT IT SAYS

A short psalm. The Lord reigns, clothed in majesty and strength, and the world he made can't be moved. His throne has stood since long before the floods began. The floods raise their voice and their pounding waves, but above the roar of many waters, the Lord on high is mightier.

FOR YOUR KNOT

The flood is loud, not final. Write your three loudest worries on a slip of paper, and write God's name across the top of it. Then fold it and put it in the Bible, under this psalm.

> *Above the voices of many waters, the mighty breakers of the sea, the LORD on high is mighty.*
>
> PSALM 93:4 (WEB)

Lord, the water is loud, and you are louder. Hold my house steady today, and let me stand on what doesn't move.



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PSALM 94

When injustice stings, the Lord does not forsake his people.

READ IT WHEN…

someone got away with hurting you, and it stings all over again every time you see them smile in public.

PSALM 94

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer asks the God of justice to rise up, because the proud brag and push around the widow and the stranger. He argues that the God who made the ear and the eye surely hears and sees. When his foot was slipping, God's love held him up, and when his worries multiplied, God's comfort cheered his soul.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Handing the case to God isn't pretending it didn't happen. Say what was done, out loud, in order, then say, "You see it." Forgiving often starts right there, and it's a better place to start than "it's fine."

> *For the LORD won't reject his people, neither will he forsake his inheritance.*
>
> PSALM 94:14 (WEB)

Lord, you saw what was done to me. I hand you the case. Hold me up when I slip, and loosen this grudge a little at a time.



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PSALM 95

Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your heart.



READ IT WHEN…

you've gotten stubborn, with God, with your sister, with yourself, and you can feel your heart going hard.

WHAT IT SAYS

The psalm opens with an invitation to come and sing and kneel before God our Maker, who holds the whole earth and shepherds us like sheep. Then it turns serious: today, if you hear his voice, don't harden your heart the way your fathers did in the wilderness.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Soft is not weak. Do the first small thing you've been refusing: pick up the phone, say "I was wrong," or just sit down across from them and let the coffee go cold. Today, the psalm says. Not next week.

> *for he is our God. We are the people of his pasture, and the sheep in his care. Today, oh that you would hear his voice!*
>
> PSALM 95:7 (WEB)

Lord, I want to hear you today. Soften what has gone hard in me, and give me the nerve to take the first small step.



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PSALM 96

Sing to the Lord a new song; declare his glory each day.

READ IT WHEN…

your heart is heavy and you can't remember the last time you sang anything, even alone in the kitchen.

WHAT IT SAYS

The psalm calls the whole earth to sing a new song and tell of God's glory day after day. The gods of the nations are idols, it says, but the Lord made the heavens. By the end the sea, the fields and even the trees are singing for joy.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You don't have to feel it first. Hum one old hymn while you do the dishes. The feeling often shows up in the second verse, not the first.

Sing to the LORD a new song! Sing to the LORD, all the earth.

PSALM 96:1 (WEB)

Lord, I haven't got a new song, only a tired old voice. Take it anyway. Let me sing one line for you today, and mean it.



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PSALM 97

Light is sown for the righteous, and gladness for the upright.

READ IT WHEN…

you've been through a long hard stretch, and you'd like to believe the light is coming but need one word to hold.

PSALM 97

WHAT IT SAYS

The Lord reigns. Clouds and darkness surround him, yet justice and right are the foundation of his throne, and the heavens declare his righteousness. For those who love him, the psalm says, light is sown like seed, and gladness for the upright in heart.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Seed is slow, and it's out of sight. Think of one small good thing you planted, a kindness, a prayer, a phone call, that hasn't come up yet. Give it one more day before you decide nothing's growing.

> *Light is sown for the righteous, and gladness for the upright in heart.*
>
> PSALM 97:11 (WEB)

Lord, I believe there is light planted somewhere in this. Keep me patient while it grows, and show me one small green thing today.



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PSALM 98

Sing to the Lord a new song; he has done marvelous things.

READ IT WHEN...

some good news came this week, small or large, and you haven't yet said thank you to anyone, including God.

PSALM 98

WHAT IT SAYS

A song for what God has done. He has remembered his love and faithfulness, and the whole earth has seen his salvation. The writer calls for harps and trumpets and shouting, and even the rivers clap their hands while the mountains sing together.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Good news deserves a witness. Tell one person today what went right, and thank the Lord in the same breath. Don't downplay it with "it was nothing, really."

Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth! Burst out and sing for joy, yes, sing praises!

PSALM 98:4 (WEB)

Lord, thank you for the good thing I almost let slip by. I'm saying it out loud so it doesn't get lost. You did this.



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PSALM 99

The Lord is holy: a quiet psalm for an unquiet mind.

READ IT WHEN…

your mind is racing and you need a psalm that makes you sit still and lets God be God.

PSALM 99

WHAT IT SAYS

The Lord reigns and he is holy, and the peoples are told to tremble and bow down at his footstool. He loves justice. The psalm remembers Moses, Aaron and Samuel, who called on him and were answered, and says he forgave them while still holding them to account.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Holy means "not like us," and that's good news when you've been trying to run everything. Sit one full minute with your hands open on your lap, palms up, and let the list wait.

Moses and Aaron were among his priests, Samuel was among those who call on his name. They called on the LORD, and he answered them.

PSALM 99:6 (WEB)

Lord, you are holy, and I'm not in charge. I put down the list for one minute. Answer me the way you answered them.



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PSALM 100

Enter his gates with thanksgiving: the thank-you psalm.

READ IT WHEN…

you sit down to an ordinary meal or an ordinary morning and want to say thank you before you say anything else.

PSALM 100

WHAT IT SAYS

Five short verses. Shout for joy, serve with gladness, and know that he made us and we are his, the sheep of his pasture. Come into his gates with thanks and into his courts with praise, because the Lord is good, his love lasts forever, and his faithfulness reaches every generation.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say three thank-yous out loud before you ask for anything today. Be specific: the coffee, the clean sheets, the call you got on Tuesday. Specific thanks get past the heart's defenses better than general ones.

Enter into his gates with thanksgiving, and into his courts with praise. Give thanks to him, and bless his name.

PSALM 100:4 (WEB)

Lord, before I ask for a thing, thank you for the bed, the bread and the people who still call. I am yours. Thank you.



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PSALM 101

I will walk with integrity within my house.

READ IT WHEN…

you want your home to be a place of honesty and peace, and you're ready to start with yourself.

WHAT IT SAYS

A person makes a promise about his own house: I will live a blameless life, I will set nothing vile before my eyes, and I won't put up with secret slander or lies under my roof. It's a vow made first to God, and then to the family.

FOR YOUR KNOT

A faithful home starts with one person's promise, and it can be yours. Pick one thing you'll stop doing in your house: the sarcasm, the silence at dinner, the phone at the table. Tell one person at home what it is.

I will be careful to live a blameless life. When will you come to me? I will walk within my house with a blameless heart.

PSALM 101:2 (WEB)

Lord, I want to be the same person in my kitchen as I am in your church. Help me keep one promise in this house today.



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PSALM 102

FOR THE NIGHT

Like a lonely bird on the housetop: the prayer of the afflicted.

READ IT WHEN…

the house is quiet, the phone isn't ringing, and you feel like the last bird on the roof.

WHAT IT SAYS

This is the prayer of someone worn thin. He can't eat, he groans, he lies awake like a sparrow alone on the housetop. Then he looks up and says: you, Lord, remain forever. He ends by saying God has not despised the prayer of the destitute.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Being lonely isn't proof that you're forgotten. Ask God to sit on the roof with you tonight. Tomorrow, call one person, even for a minute, and say "I was thinking of you." Most people will be glad you did.

> *I watch, and have become like a sparrow that is alone on the housetop.*
>
> PSALM 102:7 (WEB)

Lord, I'm the bird on the roof tonight. Sit here with me. Don't despise my prayer, and give me one voice to call tomorrow.



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PSALM 103

He forgives all your sins and crowns you with love: bless the Lord.

READ IT WHEN…

an old sin is still sitting at your kitchen table, and you want to believe it has really been forgiven.

PSALM 103

WHAT IT SAYS

A song of thanks that lists what God does: he forgives all your sins, redeems your life from the pit, and crowns you with love and tender mercy. He's slow to anger. He doesn't treat us as our sins deserve, and he moves them as far from us as east is from west. He knows we're only dust.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Carry the old sin to him one more time, and set it down. Then do what the psalm says: "forget not all his benefits." Name one kindness from this month, out loud, before you go to bed.

> *As far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us.*
>
> PSALM 103:12 (WEB)

Lord, you know what I'm made of. Take the old sin off my table and put it as far away as you say. Let me stop carrying it.



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PSALM 104

Everything on earth depends on his open hand.

READ IT WHEN…

you look at the small things on your table, the bread, the window, a bird at the feeder, and you want to see them as gifts.

PSALM 104

WHAT IT SAYS

A long song about creation. God wears light like a garment, sends springs into the valleys, makes grass for the animals and plants for people, and gives wine and oil and bread. All living things look to him for their food, and he opens his hand and they are filled.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Eat one meal slowly today and say whose hand it came from, from seed to stove. Worry has less room when the table is seen as a gift.

wine that makes the heart of man glad, oil to make his face to shine, and bread that strengthens man's heart.

PSALM 104:15 (WEB)

Lord, thank you for the bread on my table and the light in my window. You open your hand, and I am fed. Amen.



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PSALM 105

Remember the wonders he has done in your own life.

READ IT WHEN…

you've been staring only at what's missing, and you need to look back at what was given.

WHAT IT SAYS

The psalm retells a long story, from Abraham through Joseph, who was sold as a slave and later raised up, to the way out of Egypt. The point is that God remembers his promise, so his people should remember what he's done and tell it to others.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Write down three times God showed up in your own life, even small ones, such as a check that arrived or a stranger who helped. Keep the paper in a place you'll find it on a bad day.

Remember his marvelous works that he has done: his wonders, and the judgments of his mouth,

PSALM 105:5 (WEB)

Lord, I've been counting what I lack. Help me remember three times you showed up for me, and thank you for each one.



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PSALM 106

We have sinned like our fathers: he remembered his covenant.

READ IT WHEN…

you've failed again, you're afraid to knock, and you need to know the door still opens for you.

WHAT IT SAYS

The people confess openly: we have sinned, as our fathers did. The psalm tells of times they forgot God and were rescued anyway, again and again, because he remembered his promise and took pity when they cried out.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Your failing is no news to him. Come back the way they did: say plainly what happened, no long speeches, and ask to be remembered. A door you've walked through ten times is still a door.

Remember me, LORD, with the favor that you show to your people. Visit me with your salvation,

PSALM 106:4 (WEB)

Lord, I've done it again, and you know it. I'm not going to hide. Remember me with your favor, and let me come back in.



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PSALM 107

Let the redeemed of the Lord say so: stories of those brought home.

READ IT WHEN…

you're in a tight spot, hungry for a way out, and you want to hear that others have been brought home.

PSALM 107

WHAT IT SAYS

Four groups of people in trouble: lost in the wilderness, sitting in darkness, sick from their own foolishness, tossed on a stormy sea. Each one cries out to the Lord in their trouble, and each time he brings them out. After every rescue the refrain is the same: let them give thanks.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Whatever you're in, a group on this list is in it too. Find yours, and cry out the way they did, in your own words. Then watch for the small way out, a call returned, a door left open, and thank him for it when it comes.

Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them out of their distresses.

PSALM 107:6 (WEB)

Lord, I'm in trouble, and I'm crying out. You brought them home. Bring me home too, and I'll tell everyone.



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PSALM 108

With God we will do valiantly: courage for a new try.

READ IT WHEN…

you're starting something new after a setback, and you doubt you've got the strength left to try again.

PSALM 108

WHAT IT SAYS

A morning song: my heart is steady, I will wake the dawn. God's love is higher than the heavens. Then comes a plea for help, because human help is worthless, and the psalm ends with confidence: through God we will do valiantly.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Courage isn't feeling ready. It's one small step with God in it. Decide what the first small step of the new try is, a phone call, a form, an application, and take it before noon.

Through God, we will do valiantly, for it is he who will tread down our enemies.

PSALM 108:13 (WEB)

Lord, I'm afraid to start over. Go with me into the first small step, and give me strength for the next one too.



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PSALM 109

When the whole town speaks against you, give yourself to prayer.

READ IT WHEN…

people have been saying untrue things about you, and you're tempted to answer them before you've answered to God.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer is surrounded by lies and hatred. In return for my love, he says, they accuse me, but I am in prayer. Part of the psalm asks God for hard justice on the one who hurt him, and it doesn't hide that. It ends with thanks, because God stands at the right hand of the needy.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Tell God what they said about you before you tell anyone else. All of it, even the ugly parts. Then wait a day before you answer anyone. Let the prayer go first.

> *In return for my love, they are my adversaries; but I am in prayer.*
>
> PSALM 109:4 (WEB)

Lord, they've said things that aren't true. I'm handing them to you. Keep my tongue quiet, and don't let my love turn into bitterness.



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PSALM 110

A psalm of promise: the Lord says to my Lord.

READ IT WHEN…

you want to see the bigger story behind a small day, and need a promise with the word "until" in it.

PSALM 110

WHAT IT SAYS

A royal psalm. God says to the king: sit at my right hand until I make your enemies your footstool. The king is called a priest forever, in the order of Melchizedek. Christians have long heard Jesus in these words, and the Church prays it in that light.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Hope doesn't need everything settled today. Sit with what's unfinished, and say the word "until." He is still working on the other side of it, where you can't see.

the LORD says to my Lord, "Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool for your feet.

PSALM 110:1 (WEB)

Lord, you said 'until,' so I'll wait. Keep working on what I can't finish, and help me sit down beside what's still unfinished.



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PSALM 111

His works are great: a thank-you for the daily bread.

READ IT WHEN…

you open the pantry or sit down to eat, and you feel thankful, or at least wish you did.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer thanks God with his whole heart in the company of the upright. God's works are great, and he is gracious and merciful. He has given food to those who fear him, and he always remembers his covenant. It ends with a famous line: the fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say grace slowly today, not on the way to the fork. Name the one dish or the one person at the table you're glad is there, and tell them.

He has given food to those who fear him. He always remembers his covenant.

PSALM 111:5 (WEB)

Lord, thank you for what's on this table and who's at it. You always remember us. Let me remember you, too.



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PSALM 112

The upright are blessed: a steady heart in a house in order.

READ IT WHEN…

the mail is sitting unopened on the table, you're afraid of what's in it, and the phone might bring bad news.

PSALM 112

WHAT IT SAYS

Blessed is the person who fears the Lord and delights in his commands. This person is generous, lends freely, and gives to the poor. He will not be afraid of bad news; his heart is steady, trusting in the Lord. Light rises in the dark for the upright.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Open the mail with this verse in your pocket: "He will not be afraid of evil tidings." Then set aside one small amount to give away, even a few dollars. Giving something away steadies the heart, strange as that sounds.

He will not be afraid of evil news. His heart is steadfast, trusting in the LORD.

PSALM 112:7 (WEB)

Lord, I'm afraid of the next envelope. Steady my heart, and teach me the next small thing to do with what I have.



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PSALM 113

He lifts the poor from the dust and makes the childless woman joyful.

READ IT WHEN…

you've longed for a child, or for a grandchild to live close by, or you've felt overlooked for years.

PSALM 113

WHAT IT SAYS

Praise the name of the Lord from sunrise to sunset. He is high above everything, yet he stoops down to look. He lifts the poor from the dust, seats them with princes, and gives the childless woman a home as a happy mother of children.

FOR YOUR KNOT

The longing for a child, or for a child nearby, is something he stoops to see. Say it to him once, plainly, with the name of the one you're missing, and let him hear it.

He raises up the poor out of the dust, and lifts up the needy from the ash heap,

PSALM 113:7 (WEB)

Lord, you stoop down to see the small. Look at this ache for my family. Lift it from the dust, and bring them close.



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PSALM 114

Tremble, earth, at the presence of the Lord.

READ IT WHEN…

something has shaken you badly this year, and you need to remember who is truly in charge of the shaking.

PSALM 114

WHAT IT SAYS

When Israel left Egypt, the sea ran away and the Jordan turned back. The mountains skipped like rams and the hills like lambs. The earth is told to tremble before the Lord, who turned the rock into a pool of water.

FOR YOUR KNOT

If the ground shook for him, it can shake for you without breaking you. Say "Tremble, earth," out loud, and then go make your coffee. He's in charge of the shaking, and you are not.

Tremble, you earth, at the presence of the Lord, at the presence of the God of Jacob,

PSALM 114:7 (WEB)

Lord, the ground is shaking under me. You made rock into water. I put my feet in your hands, and I'm staying put.



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PSALM 115

Not to us, O Lord, but to your name give glory.

READ IT WHEN…

you put your trust in a plan, a savings account or a person, and it let you down.

PSALM 115

WHAT IT SAYS

Not to us, but to your name give glory. The idols of the nations are silver and gold, made by human hands: they have mouths and can't speak, eyes and can't see, ears and can't hear. Trust the Lord, the psalm says, because he is their help and their shield, and he blesses the small and the great.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Ask yourself what you've been leaning on instead of God. You don't have to throw it away, only lean on it a little less. Name it out loud to him today.

Not to us, LORD, not to us, but to your name give glory, for your loving kindness, and for your truth's sake.

PSALM 115:1 (WEB)

Lord, I've leaned on things that can't hold me. Be my help and my shield today, and let the credit be yours.



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PSALM 116

I was brought low and he saved me: a prayer of recovery.

READ IT WHEN...

you're getting back on your feet after a hard time, and you want to say thank you without a lot of words.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer loves God because he listened when the cords of death were tight around him. I was brought low, he says, and he saved me. Now he asks what he can give back. He will lift the cup of salvation, call on God's name, and keep his promises in front of everyone.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Gratitude can have a to-do list. Thank the one who sat with you in the hard days, a nurse, a neighbor, a daughter, and tell one person out loud what you came through.

> *the LORD preserves the simple. I was brought low, and he saved me.*
>
> PSALM 116:6 (WEB)

Lord, I was brought low, and you stayed. Thank you for the hands that held me up. Show me what I can give back.



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PSALM 117

The shortest psalm: two verses to say when you have no words.

READ IT WHEN…

you've got no words left at all, and you need something short enough to say with a shaking voice.

WHAT IT SAYS

Only two verses. All the nations and all the peoples are called to praise the Lord. The reason is simple: his love toward us is great, and his faithfulness lasts forever. It's the shortest psalm in the Bible, and it's enough.

FOR YOUR KNOT

When there are no words, these two lines are enough. Say them slowly, twice, and make the second time quieter than the first.

For his loving kindness is great toward us. The LORD's faithfulness endures forever. Praise Yah!

PSALM 117:2 (WEB)

Lord, I have no words today, only these two lines. Your love is great and your faithfulness lasts. That's enough for me now.



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PSALM 118

His mercy endures forever: this is the day the Lord has made.

READ IT WHEN…

you wake up and the day is just a day, with nothing special in it, and you want to decide to be glad of it.

PSALM 118

WHAT IT SAYS

A thanksgiving that keeps repeating: his love endures forever. Out of my distress I called, the writer says, and he answered me and set me free. The Lord is on my side, so I won't be afraid. It's better to take refuge in the Lord than to trust in princes, and the day he made is a day to be glad.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Gladness can be a decision you make before breakfast. Say the verse once before you open the curtains, and see how the day looks afterward.

This is the day that the LORD has made. We will rejoice and be glad in it!

PSALM 118:24 (WEB)

Lord, this is the day you made. I haven't earned it, and I will be glad in it. Be on my side today.



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PSALM 119

Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path.

READ IT WHEN…

you must decide something important and can't see farther than the next step in front of your feet.

PSALM 119

WHAT IT SAYS

The longest psalm is an alphabet poem of 176 verses, one stanza for each letter of the Hebrew alphabet, and nearly every line is about loving God's word. It calls the word a lamp for the feet and a light for the path, something to hide in the heart. Again and again the writer asks: teach me.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You don't need the whole road lit, only the next step. Ask for the next step, and take it before you ask for the one after. Read just eight verses today, one stanza, and stop.

Your word is a lamp to my feet, and a light for my path.

PSALM 119:105 (WEB)

Lord, I can't see the whole road. Light the next step under my feet, and give me the nerve to put my foot down.



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PSALM 120

In my distress I cried to the Lord, and he answered.

READ IT WHEN…

you live among people who twist your words, and you're tired of working so hard for peace at home.

PSALM 120

WHAT IT SAYS

A short cry. In my distress I called to the Lord and he answered me. The writer asks to be saved from lying lips and deceitful tongues. He has lived too long among those who hate peace: I am for peace, he says, but when I speak, they are for war.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Wanting peace and not getting it back is a real grief. Say that to God first. Then decide one thing you won't argue about today, and let it go by without a word.

In my distress, I cried to the LORD. He answered me.

PSALM 120:1 (WEB)

Lord, I want peace, and some people want a fight. Answer me as you did before, and keep my lips from deceit.



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PSALM 121

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

"He who keeps you will not slumber": the psalm for the 3 a.m. hour.

READ IT WHEN…

it's three in the morning, the house is dark, and you need to know that someone else is awake.

PSALM 121

WHAT IT SAYS

A traveler lifts his eyes to the hills and asks where his help comes from. The answer: from the Lord, who made heaven and earth. The one who keeps you does not slumber or sleep. He's your shade at your right hand, and he keeps your going out and your coming in, now and always.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You can stop keeping watch. Someone else is already on the night shift. Set the worry down like a heavy coat on a hook, and let him hold it until morning.

> *He will not allow your foot to be moved. He who keeps you will not slumber.*
>
> PSALM 121:3 (WEB)

Lord, you don't sleep, so I can. Take the watch tonight. Keep my feet, my house and the ones I love, and wake me gently.



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PSALM 122

I was glad when they said: peace be within your walls.

READ IT WHEN…

you're about to walk into your house after a hard day and want to carry peace in with you.

PSALM 122

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer is glad when they say, "Let's go to the house of the Lord." He prays for peace within the walls and security within the palaces. For the sake of his family and friends, he says, "Peace be within you," and for the house of the Lord he asks only for their good.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say "peace be in this house" at the front door when you come in, even if nobody hears you. Let the first thing through the door be peace, and the rest of the day follows.

Peace be within your walls, and prosperity within your palaces.

PSALM 122:7 (WEB)

Lord, let peace be within these walls today. Let me carry it in with me, and let the first word at the door be a kind one.



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PSALM 123

Have mercy on us; we have had more than enough of contempt.

READ IT WHEN…

someone looked down on you because of your money or your situation, and the shame is still burning.

PSALM 123

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer lifts his eyes to God, the way servants watch their master's hand, and waits until God has mercy. Then he says plainly: we've had more than enough of scorn, more than enough of the contempt of the proud.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Shame about money weighs more than the debt does. Tell God what was said to you, word for word. He looks at you with mercy, not scorn, and that includes how he looks at your bank balance.

Have mercy on us, LORD, have mercy on us, for we have endured much contempt.

PSALM 123:3 (WEB)

Lord, I've had enough of being looked down on. I look to you like a servant to a hand. Have mercy, and lift my head.



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PSALM 124

If the Lord hadn't been on our side, the waters would have won.

READ IT WHEN…

you've just come through something that could have swallowed you whole, and you're still shaking a little inside.

PSALM 124

WHAT IT SAYS

If the Lord hadn't been on our side, the writer says, the waters would have gone over us and the stream would have swallowed us. Instead, we've escaped like a bird from the hunter's trap. The trap is broken, and we are free. Our help is in the name of the Lord, who made heaven and earth.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say what it could have been, and then thank him for what it wasn't. Naming the near miss turns the shaking into thanks. Do it with someone who was there, if they're alive.

> *Our soul has escaped like a bird out of the fowler's snare. The snare is broken, and we have escaped.*
>
> PSALM 124:7 (WEB)

Lord, I could have been swept away, and I wasn't. The trap is broken, and I'm free. Thank you for being on my side.



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PSALM 125

Those who trust in the Lord are like Mount Zion, which cannot be moved.

READ IT WHEN…

the ground is moving under you, the job, your health, the family, and you want something that stays put.

WHAT IT SAYS

Those who trust in the Lord are like Mount Zion, which can't be moved. As the mountains surround Jerusalem, so the Lord surrounds his people, now and forever. The psalm ends with a short prayer: do good to those who are good, and let there be peace.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You're not asked to feel like a mountain. You're asked to be surrounded by one. Stand with your back against a wall and say, "He is around me." Feel the wall for a minute.

> *As the mountains surround Jerusalem, so the LORD surrounds his people from this time forward and forever more.*
>
> PSALM 125:2 (WEB)

Lord, I don't feel like a mountain, but you're around me like one. Hold me steady when the ground moves under me.



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PSALM 126

Those who sow in tears will reap with songs of joy.

READ IT WHEN…

you've cried over someone far away, and you wonder whether all that crying has been for nothing.

PSALM 126

WHAT IT SAYS

The people remember the day they were brought home: it was like a dream, with laughter and singing. Now they ask God to restore them again, like streams in dry ground. The psalm says those who sow in tears will reap with joy, and one who goes out weeping, carrying seed, comes home carrying sheaves.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Your tears can be seed. Do one small act of care for the one you miss: a note, a message, a prayer by name. Then leave the harvest to God; it isn't yours to hurry.

> *Those who sow in tears will reap in joy.*
>
> PSALM 126:5 (WEB)

Lord, I've sown a lot in tears. Take these tears as seed, and bring the one I miss home with joy, in your time.



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✦ PSALM 127 ✦

☾ For the night

Unless the Lord builds the house: he gives his beloved sleep.

READ IT WHEN…

you've worked all day, and half the night, to hold the house up, and you can't let go of it.

PSALM 127

WHAT IT SAYS

Unless the Lord builds the house, those who build it work in vain. It's no use getting up early and staying up late, eating the bread of hard work, because God gives sleep to the ones he loves. Children, the psalm adds, are a gift from the Lord.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Tonight, leave one thing unfixed. Leave the dishes or the numbers, tell the one beside you, "We'll let him hold it," and go to bed. Do it on purpose, and see what the morning looks like.

> *It is vain for you to rise up early, to stay up late, eating the bread of toil, for he gives sleep to his loved ones.*
>
> PSALM 127:2 (WEB)

Lord, I can't build this house alone. I'm putting down the tools. Hold the house tonight, and give me the sleep you give to those you love.



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PSALM 128

Your children like olive shoots around your table.

READ IT WHEN…

you look at your table, full or half empty, and want to bless the family that sits there, or used to.

PSALM 128

WHAT IT SAYS

A blessing for the person who follows God. You'll eat the fruit of your own work, and it will be well with you. Your family will be around your table like olive shoots. The psalm ends by hoping you'll see your children's children, and peace in your home.

FOR YOUR KNOT

If the table is smaller now, bless it as it is. Say each name aloud, the ones here and the ones gone, and ask the Lord to keep them well. Then set the table the way you would if they were all coming.

> *Your wife will be as a fruitful vine in the innermost parts of your house, your children like olive shoots around your table.*
>
> PSALM 128:3 (WEB)

Lord, bless this table and everyone who sits at it, and everyone who used to. Keep us close, and let there be peace.



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PSALM 129

They have afflicted me from my youth, yet they have not prevailed.

READ IT WHEN…

you've carried the same trouble most of your life, you're still standing, and nobody seems to have noticed.

WHAT IT SAYS

Many times, the writer says, they have afflicted me from my youth, and yet they haven't beaten me. The plowers plowed my back, but the Lord is righteous and has cut the cords of the wicked. The psalm ends in a bitter wish against those who hate God's people.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Count what hasn't beaten you. Write "not prevailed" next to your oldest burden, and look at how many years you've been standing. That's a record, even if no one has congratulated you.

> *many times they have afflicted me from my youth up, yet they have not prevailed against me.*
>
> PSALM 129:2 (WEB)

Lord, it's been a long time, and I'm still here. You kept me on my feet. Cut the cords that are left, and thank you.



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PSALM 130

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

Out of the depths I cry to you: with you there is forgiveness.

READ IT WHEN…

you're awake over something you did, or didn't do, years ago, and the regret has come back with the dark.

WHAT IT SAYS

Out of the depths the writer cries to the Lord and asks him to listen. If God kept a record of sins, who could stand? But there is forgiveness with him. The writer waits for the Lord more than a night watchman waits for the morning.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Put the old regret into one sentence: "there is forgiveness with you." Say it over the regret, then wait the way a night watchman waits, knowing morning comes whether he's ready or not.

> *But there is forgiveness with you, therefore you are feared.*
>
> PSALM 130:4 (WEB)

Lord, I'm in the depths with an old regret. You don't keep a record. Forgive me, and I'll wait for morning with you.



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✦ PSALM 131 ✦

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

A quieted soul, like a weaned child with its mother.

READ IT WHEN…

your mind is going round and round like a washing machine, with questions you can't answer, and you can't make it stop.

WHAT IT SAYS

Three short verses. The writer says his heart isn't proud, and he doesn't take on great matters that are too wonderful for him. Instead he has stilled and quieted his soul, like a weaned child resting with its mother.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You don't have to figure it out tonight. Rest like a child on a lap that isn't asking for anything, and let the questions wait until daylight. Write one on a pad by the bed if it won't leave you, and go back to sleep.

> *Surely I have stilled and quieted my soul, like a weaned child with his mother, like a weaned child is my soul within me.*
>
> PSALM 131:2 (WEB)

Lord, I put down the questions that are too big for me. Quiet my soul like a child on its mother's lap, and let me rest.



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PSALM 132

A prayer to make a dwelling for him in your home.

READ IT WHEN…

you want your house to be a place where God is at home, and not just a place he visits on feast days.

WHAT IT SAYS

The king promises he won't rest until he finds a place for the Lord to live. In answer, God says he has chosen Zion as his resting place forever. He will bless its poor with bread and clothe his people with joy.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Make a small place: a chair, a shelf, a candle where you pray each day. Keep it clear of mail and keys, and come back to it at the same time every day, even for two minutes.

> *This is my resting place forever. I will live here, for I have desired it.*
>
> PSALM 132:14 (WEB)

Lord, I'm making a small place for you in this house. Come and rest in it, and meet me there each day.



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PSALM 133

How good and pleasant when brothers live together in unity.

READ IT WHEN…

a quarrel has split the family, and the empty chairs at the table hurt more than the argument ever did.

PSALM 133

WHAT IT SAYS

A tiny psalm. How good and pleasant it is when brothers and sisters live together in unity. It's like fine oil running down, like the dew of the mountains, because that is where the Lord gives his blessing, life forevermore.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Quarrels outlive their causes. Be the first to say the other person's name kindly today, out loud, even in an empty room. A kind word said where no one hears it still changes the one who says it.

See how good and how pleasant it is for brothers to live together in unity!

PSALM 133:1 (WEB)

Lord, I'm tired of this quarrel. Soften us both, and make a way for us to sit at one table again, in peace.



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PSALM 134

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

Lift up your hands in the sanctuary at night and bless the Lord.

READ IT WHEN…

you're awake in the night anyway, and you decide you may as well keep the watch with him.

PSALM 134

WHAT IT SAYS

A very short song for the night watch. The servants who stand in the Lord's house by night are told to lift their hands and bless him. Then comes a blessing back: may the Lord, who made heaven and earth, bless you from Zion.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Make the night shift a prayer. Lift your hands off the blanket and bless one person by name. Awake with a purpose is a different kind of awake.

Lift up your hands in the sanctuary. Praise the LORD!

PSALM 134:2 (WEB)

Lord, I'm awake, so I'll keep the watch with you. I lift my hands and bless you, and I bless the ones I love.



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PSALM 135

Praise his name: he is good, he does what he pleases.

READ IT WHEN…

the day was a mix of good and bad, and you decide to stand up and say who he is anyway.

PSALM 135

WHAT IT SAYS

The psalm calls God's servants to praise his name, because he is good. He does whatever he pleases in heaven and on earth, makes clouds rise and rain fall, and sets his people free. The idols of silver and gold can't speak or hear, and God will have compassion on his servants.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Praise doesn't need a good mood. Say three things you know are true about God, and say them whatever kind of day it's been. Say them as facts, not feelings.

> *Praise Yah, for the LORD is good. Sing praises to his name, for that is pleasant.*
>
> PSALM 135:3 (WEB)

Lord, the day was mixed, and you are good. You do what you please, and you pity your servants. Thank you for both.



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PSALM 136

His mercy endures forever: said twenty-six times.

READ IT WHEN…

you can't find one fresh word of thanks, and you'd like to say the same line over and over.

WHAT IT SAYS

Twenty-six verses with the same refrain: his love endures forever. The psalm walks through the making of the heavens, the sun and the moon, the rescue from Egypt, and the daily food he gives to every living thing. After each thing named, the same line.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Repeat the line while you wash a plate or fold the laundry, until you believe it a little more each time. Twenty-six times is a good evening's dishes.

Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his loving kindness endures forever.

PSALM 136:1 (WEB)

Lord, your love endures forever. I'll say it again, and then again, until my heart agrees with my mouth. Your love endures.



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PSALM 137

By the rivers of Babylon we sat and wept: for those far from home.

READ IT WHEN...

you're far from home, from a country or a person, and someone asks you to sing when you can't.

PSALM 137

WHAT IT SAYS

The exiles sit by foreign rivers and weep as they remember Zion. They hang up their harps. Their captors ask for songs, and they answer: how can we sing the Lord's song in a foreign land? The psalm ends with an angry outburst, an honest cry from a wounded people.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Grief that can't sing is allowed. Name what you left behind, and cry the way they did. The bitter last lines you can leave in his hands; you don't have to say them yourself.

By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down. Yes, we wept, when we remembered Zion.

PSALM 137:1 (WEB)

Lord, I'm far from home and I can't sing. Take my tears as my song, and carry me back to where I belong.



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PSALM 138

You answered me on the day I called.

READ IT WHEN…

something you prayed for has come through, even partly, and you want to say so before you forget.

PSALM 138

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer thanks God with his whole heart. He bows toward God's temple and gives thanks for his love and truth. On the day I called, you answered me, he says, and you made me bold with strength in my soul. Though God is high, he looks after the lowly.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Be specific. Thank him for the thing you asked for, and for the strength you didn't know you'd been given in the meantime. Write it on the calendar page where you first asked.

> *In the day that I called, you answered me. You encouraged me with strength in my soul.*
>
> PSALM 138:3 (WEB)

Lord, you answered me when I called. Thank you for the answer, and for the strength I didn't know I had.



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PSALM 139

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

You know me when I sit and when I rise; where could I flee?

READ IT WHEN…

you feel unseen, a face in the crowd, the one nobody asks how she or he is really doing.

PSALM 139

WHAT IT SAYS

You have searched me and you know me, the writer says. You know when I sit and when I stand, you know my thoughts and the words before I speak them. I can't go anywhere you aren't, even in the dark, because to you the darkness is as light as day.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Somebody sees you right now, in this chair, in this light. Let that be enough for tonight. You don't have to be understood by everyone, only known by one.

the LORD, you have searched me, and you know me. You know my sitting down and my rising up. You perceive my thoughts from afar.

PSALM 139:1-2 (WEB)

Lord, you know me better than I know myself. Even in the dark, you see me. Let that be my rest tonight.



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PSALM 140

Rescue me from cruel tongues, and keep my steps from their traps.

READ IT WHEN…

someone's words cut you today, and you keep replaying them like a scratched record.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer begs to be rescued from violent, deceitful people whose tongues are sharp as a snake's and who have set traps for his feet. He says to the Lord, "You are my God." He trusts that God will take up the cause of the afflicted and the needy.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say the cruel words to God, once, and let them stop there. Don't carry them to the kitchen table and replay them for everyone who'll listen. Each retelling cuts you again.

> *the LORD, keep me from the hands of the wicked. Preserve me from the violent men who have determined to trip my feet.*
>
> PSALM 140:4 (WEB)

Lord, those words are still cutting me. Keep my feet from their traps, and keep my own tongue from handing them back.



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PSALM 141

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

Let my prayer rise like incense; let my hands be an evening offering.

READ IT WHEN…

the lamp is on at the end of the day, and you want your last prayer to rise like smoke.

PSALM 141

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer calls on the Lord and asks to be heard quickly. Let my prayer rise like incense, he says, and the lifting of my hands be like the evening sacrifice. He asks God to put a guard over his mouth and keep him from evil. His eyes are on God for refuge.

FOR YOUR KNOT

End the day by lifting your hands, empty, and let that be the whole prayer. Then ask for a guard on your tongue for the next conversation, the one you're already dreading.

Let my prayer be set before you like incense; the lifting up of my hands like the evening sacrifice.

PSALM 141:2 (WEB)

Lord, here are my open hands at the end of the day. Take what I did and what I didn't do, and guard my mouth for tomorrow.



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PSALM 142

FOR THE NIGHT

No one cares for my soul: you are my refuge.

READ IT WHEN…

you feel nobody cares whether you're in the room or out of it, and the phone and the chairs are silent.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer is hiding, perhaps in a cave. He pours out his complaint and tells God his troubles. He looks around and sees that no one cares for his soul. Then he cries, "You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living."

FOR YOUR KNOT

Say out loud who has left you out. Then ask yourself who might be waiting for you to call first, and call one of them tomorrow.

> *I cried to you, the LORD. I said, "You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living.*
>
> PSALM 142:5 (WEB)

Lord, nobody seems to care, and I'm telling you so. You are my refuge. Care for my soul, and send one person my way.



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PSALM 143

☾ FOR THE NIGHT

Do not enter into judgment with your servant.

READ IT WHEN…

you're lying awake counting what you did wrong, and you want to ask for mercy, not a trial.

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer begs God to hear his prayer and not to bring him to judgment, because no one living is righteous before him. His spirit is overwhelmed. He remembers the days of old, spreads out his hands, and asks to hear of God's love in the morning and to be taught the way to go.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Stop being your own judge tonight. Ask for mercy instead of a verdict, then wait for the morning's kindness. You can reopen the case tomorrow, if you must.

> *Don’t enter into judgment with your servant, for in your sight no man living is righteous.*
>
> PSALM 143:2 (WEB)

Lord, don't put me on trial tonight. I know where I fell short. Show me mercy, and let me hear your love in the morning.



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PSALM 144

May our sons be like plants and our daughters like pillars.

READ IT WHEN…

you worry about your grown children, and you'd give anything to see them well planted and standing.

PSALM 144

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer praises God as his rock and fortress, and admits that people are like a breath, a passing shadow. He asks God to rescue him from those who lie, sings a new song, and then prays that our sons would be like strong, full-grown plants and our daughters like carved pillars.

FOR YOUR KNOT

You can't make them grow. You can water them. Send each of your children one kind word today, a text, a card, a voicemail, and say their names to God.

> *Then our sons will be like well-nurtured plants, our daughters like pillars carved to adorn a palace.*
>
> PSALM 144:12 (WEB)

Lord, I put my children in your hands. Grow them strong, and hold them up where my arms can't reach.



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PSALM 145

Every day I will bless you: the Lord is gracious and merciful.

READ IT WHEN…

you want to begin a small daily habit of thanking him, even if some days it's just one line.

PSALM 145

WHAT IT SAYS

The writer promises to praise God every day. He says God is gracious, merciful, slow to anger and great in love, and that one generation will tell the next about him. The Lord holds up all who fall, and he opens his hand to satisfy every living thing.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Start with one line each morning: "The Lord is gracious and merciful." Say it before you check the phone, for a week of mornings, and see what changes.

the LORD is gracious, merciful, slow to anger, and of great loving kindness.

PSALM 145:8 (WEB)

Lord, I'll thank you each day, even in small words. You are gracious and merciful. Hold up what has fallen in me.



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PSALM 146

He upholds the widow and the fatherless: trust him, not the powerful.

READ IT WHEN…

someone powerful, an official, a boss, a lender, a relative with money, has let you down badly this time.

PSALM 146

WHAT IT SAYS

Don't put your trust in princes, the psalm says, because they die and their plans die with them. Happy is the one whose help is the God of Jacob. He gives food to the hungry, frees prisoners, lifts those who are bowed down, and upholds the widow and the fatherless.

FOR YOUR KNOT

List who you've been waiting on to fix this. Cross out one name, and hand that waiting to God instead. You may still need to call that person; just stop leaning your whole weight on them.

Don’t put your trust in princes, in a son of man in whom there is no help.

PSALM 146:3 (WEB)

Lord, I've waited on people who can't help me. I give you the waiting. Be my help, and lift those who are bowed down.



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PSALM 147

He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds.

READ IT WHEN…

your body and your heart both hurt at once, and you need someone gentle to bind them up.

PSALM 147

WHAT IT SAYS

It's good to sing to our God. He builds up the fallen, gathers the outcasts, heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds. He counts the stars and calls each one by name, and he takes pleasure in those who hope in his love.

FOR YOUR KNOT

The One who names the stars knows your name too. Put your hand where it hurts, and say the hurt out loud to him, gently, the way you'd talk to a hurt child.

> *He heals the broken in heart,*
> *and binds up their wounds.*
>
> PSALM 147:3 (WEB)

Lord, you count the stars and you know my name. Bind up what's broken in me, in my body and in my heart.



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PSALM 148

Let everything praise him, from the sun to the snow.

READ IT WHEN…

you step outside or look out the window, and you let the whole world remind you what it's for.

WHAT IT SAYS

Praise God from the heavens: angels, sun and moon, stars. Praise him from the earth: sea creatures, lightning and hail, mountains, trees, animals and birds. Then people of every age, kings and children, old men and young women, are told to praise his name.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Go to the window. Pick one thing out there, a tree, a bird, the light on the neighbor's roof, and let it praise him for you, with you.

Praise him, sun and moon! Praise him, all you shining stars!

PSALM 148:3 (WEB)

Lord, the sun and the sparrow are praising you, and I'm joining in. Let my small voice sit among the rest, and be heard.



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PSALM 149

Let his people rejoice, even on their beds.

READ IT WHEN…

your bed has been a place of worry, and you wonder whether it could become a place of song.

WHAT IT SAYS

Sing a new song to the Lord. Praise him with dancing and tambourine, because he takes pleasure in his people and crowns the humble with salvation. Let them sing for joy on their beds, the psalm says. The last verses speak of judgment on the nations, and the Church leaves that in God's hands.

FOR YOUR KNOT

At bedtime, before the worry starts, hum one line of any hymn, right there under the covers. Joy on a pillow is a small act of trust.

Let the saints rejoice in honor. Let them sing for joy on their beds.

PSALM 149:5 (WEB)

Lord, let my bed be a place of song and not of worry. I hum your praise, and I rest in your pleasure.



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PSALM 150

The last word is praise: everything that breathes.

READ IT WHEN…

you've come to the last page of the book, and all you have left to give is your breath.

WHAT IT SAYS

The last psalm is one long call to praise. Praise God in his sanctuary and his heavens, with trumpet, harp, tambourine, dance, strings and loud cymbals. The final line: let everything that has breath praise the Lord.

FOR YOUR KNOT

Take one slow breath and let it be the praise. As long as you're breathing, you have something to pray with.

> *Let everything that has breath praise Yah! Praise Yah!*
>
> PSALM 150:6 (WEB)

Lord, I'm still breathing, so I'll praise you. Every breath is a thank-you. Let my last word, like this one, be yours.



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